



UPSC CSE 2027

ANTHROPOLOGY

OPTIONAL FOUNDATION

HANDOUT 02
INDIAN SOCIETY



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7+ Years Experience

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Indian Society
Handout 2**Paper 2– 3.2****Syllabus covered in this Handout:****PAPER 2–****Chapter 3.2– Caste system in India**

- Structure and characteristics,
- Varna and caste,
- Caste Mobility.
- Theories of Origin of Caste
- Dominant Caste
- Future of Caste System in India.

Chapter 3.4– Impact of Buddhism, Jainism, Islam and Christianity of Indian society.**Chapter 5.3–**

- Little and great traditions
- Universalisation and Parochialisation

Chapter 3.3–

- Sacred Complex
- Nature–Man–Spirit Complex.

Chapter 3.2–

- Jajmani system
- Tribe–caste continuum

Chapter 5.3–

- Sanskritization, Westernization, Modernization

Chapter 5.2–

- Religious and Linguistic minorities and their social, political and economic status.

Chapter 4–

- Growth of Anthropology in India

Chapter 5.3–

- Panchayati Raj and social change; Media and Social change.

Chapter 5.1– Indian Village:

- Significance of village study in India;
- Traditional and changing patterns of settlement and inter–caste relations,
- Little republics, Rural Cosmopolitanism,
- Agrarian relations in Indian villages,
- Impact of Globalization on Indian Village,
- Indian Village as a Social System,
- Traditional Culture.



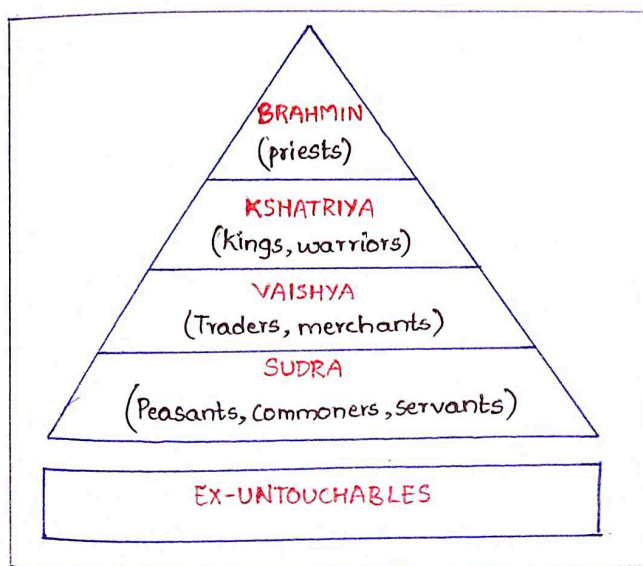
CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM

_____ defined caste as “an **endogamous** and **hereditary** subdivision of an ethnic unit occupying a position of **superior or inferior rank or social esteem** in comparison with other such subdivisions” (1930)

‘Caste’ is the name of an ancient social institution that **has been part of Indian history and culture for thousands of years**. Caste is an institution uniquely associated with the Indian subcontinent. While social arrangements producing **similar effects have existed in other parts of the world**, the exact form has not been found elsewhere. Although it is an institution characteristic of Hindu society, caste has spread to the major non-Hindu communities of the Indian sub-continent.

History:

- The English word ‘caste’ is actually a borrowing from the **Portuguese casta, meaning pure breed**.
- The word refers to a broad institutional arrangement that in Indian languages (beginning with the ancient Sanskrit) is referred to by two distinct terms, varna and Jati.
- **Varna, literally ‘colour’**, is the name given to a **four-fold division of society** into brahmana, kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra. though this excludes a significant section of the population composed of the ‘outcastes’, foreigners, slaves, conquered peoples and others, sometimes referred to as the **Panchamas or fifth category**.



- Jati is the word most commonly used to refer to the institution of caste in Indian languages, though it is interesting to note that, increasingly, Indian language speakers are beginning to use the English word ‘caste’.

Relationship between Varna and Jati/Caste:

- The precise relationship between varna and jati has been the subject of much speculation and debate among scholars.

Category	Caste	Varna
Meaning	Social group based on birth	Class system based on occupation
Origin	Developed over time through social stratification	Described in ancient Hindu texts as a four-fold division of society
Number of Categories	Many, depending on the region and religion	Four: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra
Mobility	Little to no social mobility	Theoretically, people can move up or down in varna based on their occupation and behavior
Discrimination	Discrimination is a common feature of caste-based systems	While theoretically not discriminatory, the varna system has been used to

		justify discrimination based on birth
Relevance	Caste is still a significant factor in Indian society, despite being officially outlawed	Varna has largely been superseded by caste in Indian society

- The most common interpretation is to treat **varna as a broad all-India aggregative classification, while jati is taken to be a regional or local sub-classification** involving a much more complex system consisting of hundreds or even thousands of castes and subcastes.
- This means that while the four varna classification is common to all of India, the jati hierarchy has more local classifications that vary from region to region.

In summary, the historical roots of the caste system, expressed through the terms varna and jati, reveal a complex social structure with both national and regional dimensions, contributing to the unique character of caste in the Indian subcontinent.

Varna and Buddhism:

- **Emergence of Buddhism in India:**
 - Buddhism arose in the 6th century BCE during the Second Urbanisation period, when rigid Brahmanical rituals and stratification under Varna were being questioned.
 - Scholars like Romila Thapar argue that Buddhism was both a product of and a reaction to these social conditions. It did not deny the existence of social groups but explicitly rejected the moral legitimacy of the Varna hierarchy.
- **Buddhist Teaching on Judgment:**
 - The Buddha emphasized *karma* and *intention (cetana)* as the true basis of moral worth. In the *Vasala Sutta* (Sutta Nipata), he declared that "not by birth is one an outcaste, not by birth is one a Brahmin; by action one becomes an outcaste, by action one becomes a Brahmin." This was a radical departure from Brahmanical orthodoxy.
 - Scholars like Gail Omvedt note that this teaching opened a new moral order where ethical conduct, not ritual status, determined human worth.
- **Rejection of Brahmin Authority:**
 - Buddhism denied that Brahmins alone were the custodians of sacred knowledge or the mediators of divine power. The Buddha democratized access to spiritual liberation (*Nirvana*), stressing that enlightenment was attainable through the Eightfold Path, not ritual sacrifices.
 - Johannes Bronkhorst (2011) points out that this weakened the ritual economy that had placed Brahmins at the top of the Varna system.
- **Attraction to Lower Castes:**
 - Buddhism's inclusive message, its use of local languages like Pali, and the organization of the Sangha (monastic order) attracted marginalized castes and communities.
 - Ambedkar in *The Buddha and His Dhamma* emphasized that Buddhism was a "religion of social equality" that gave dignity to the downtrodden. The archaeological record, including inscriptions at Sanchi and Bharhut, shows patronage of Buddhism by guilds and non-elite groups, further reflecting its egalitarian appeal.

Varna and Jainism:

- **Jainism as a Reform Movement:**
 - Emerging around the same time as Buddhism, Jainism too rejected Brahmanical ritualism, the Varna hierarchy, and the authority of the Vedas. Like Buddhism, it is classified among the *śramaṇa* traditions (heterodox schools).
 - Paul Dundas notes that Jainism framed an alternative worldview where liberation (*moksha*) was possible for all, regardless of caste or gender, through rigorous self-discipline.
- **Equality and Non-Discrimination**
 - Jainism upheld the principle of the fundamental equality of all living beings (*jiva*). This extended beyond humans to animals and plants, through its doctrine of *ahimsa*. By rejecting caste-based restrictions on spiritual progress, Jainism undermined the metaphysical foundations of Varna.
 - However, scholars also note a paradox: while the theology was egalitarian, in practice, Jain communities sometimes adopted caste-like structures (*jati*), showing the pull of social realities in India.



- **Ethical Principles**

- Central to Jain teaching were non-violence (*ahimsa*), truth (*satya*), non-stealing (*asteya*), celibacy (*brahmacharya*), and non-possession (*aparigraha*). These “five vows” (*mahavratas*) contrasted with the Brahmanical emphasis on ritual sacrifice.
- Padmanabh Jaini notes that Jainism turned ethics into a personal discipline aimed at liberation, rather than a collective ritual obligation linked to Varna. This ethic became especially attractive in mercantile communities, who found in it a spiritual justification for restraint and honest trade.

- **Influence on Culture and Philosophy:**

- Jainism’s emphasis on *ahimsa* profoundly shaped Indian cultural traditions, from vegetarianism to Gandhian non-violence. Mahatma Gandhi himself acknowledged Jain influences in developing his philosophy of *satyagraha*. Jain metaphysical doctrines like *anekantavada* (many-sidedness of truth) offered an epistemological alternative to rigid hierarchies, fostering intellectual pluralism.
- As Hermann Jacobi note, these ideas challenged the exclusivity of Brahmanical orthodoxy and influenced later Hindu and even modern Indian thought.

Thus, both Buddhism and Jainism arose as *śramaṇa* reform movements questioning the moral and social legitimacy of Varna. They replaced birth-based hierarchy with conduct-based ethics and opened spiritual paths to marginalized groups. While both faced challenges of caste-like practices over time, their foundational teachings continue to provide critical perspectives on the rigidity of Varna and remain relevant in debates on social justice, equality, and human dignity in India today.

Age of the Caste System:

- **Vedic Period (900–500 BCE):**

- In the late Vedic period, society was organized into four varnas.
- These divisions were relatively flexible, with scope for mobility across categories.

- **Post-Vedic Period:**

- Over time, the varna system hardened into a rigid caste structure.
- Occupations and social status became fixed and hereditary, creating the complex caste system seen in later history.

In summary, Buddhism and Jainism emerged as reform movements challenging the varna system, advocating for equality, non-discrimination, and ethical principles. The age of the caste system is generally agreed to be around three thousand years, but its nature and characteristics have evolved over time, with the post-Vedic period marking a significant transition to the more rigid caste institution familiar today.

Defining Features of Caste:

_____ wrote in 1932 that, despite much study by many people, we do not possess a real general definition of caste. It appears to me that any **attempt at definition is bound to fail** because of the **complexity** of the phenomenon. On the other hand, much literature on the subject is marred by lack of precision about the use of the term.

He offered what he thought was a definition that could be applied across India, although he acknowledged that there were **regional variations** on the general theme. His model definition for caste included the following **six characteristics**:

1. Segmentation of society into groups whose membership was **determined by birth**. This creates a hereditary system where one inherits their caste identity.
2. **Endogamy, restrictions on marrying a person outside caste**. But in some situations **hypergamy** is allowed. Far less rigidity on inter-marriage between different sub-castes than between members of different castes in some regions, while in some endogamy within a sub-caste was the principal feature of caste-society.
3. A **hierarchical system** wherein generally the Brahmins were at the head of the hierarchy, but this hierarchy was disputed in some cases. In various linguistic areas, hundreds of castes had a gradation generally acknowledged by everyone.
4. **Restrictions on feeding and social intercourse**, with minute rules on the kind of food and drink that upper castes could accept from lower castes. There was a great diversity in these rules, and lower castes generally accepted food from upper castes.
5. **Occupation, generally inherited**. Lack of unrestricted choice of profession, caste members restricted their own members from taking up certain professions they considered degrading. This characteristic of caste was missing from large parts of India, stated Ghurye, and in these regions all four castes (Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras) did agriculture labor or became warriors in large numbers.
6. **Segregation**, where individual castes lived together, the dominant caste living in the center and other castes living on the periphery. There were **restrictions on the use of water wells or streets by one caste on another**: an upper-caste Brahmin might not be permitted to use the street of a lower-caste group,



while a caste considered impure might not be permitted to draw water from a well used by members of other castes.

Limitations:

- The above Ghurye's model of caste also attracted scholarly criticism for relying on the census reports produced by the colonial government, the **"superior, inferior" racist theories of _____**, who was the 1901 Census Commissioner.
- _____ also highlights the **complexity of caste**, and notes that there are differences between **theoretical constructs** of caste and the **practical reality** of caste.

In summary, **G.S. Ghurye's** model identifies key features of caste, acknowledging regional variations and the intricate nature of this social phenomenon. The limitations of the model underscore the challenges in capturing the full complexity and diversity of caste dynamics in India.

Caste:

- These features are the prescribed **rules found in ancient scriptural texts**. Since these **prescriptions were not always practiced**, we cannot say to what extent these rules actually determined the empirical reality of caste – its concrete meaning for the people living at that time. Most of the prescriptions involved prohibitions or restrictions of various sorts.
- It is also clear from the historical evidence that **caste was a very unequal institution** – some castes benefited greatly from the system, while others were condemned to a life of endless labour and subordination.
- Most important, once caste became rigidly **determined by birth, it was in principle impossible for a person to ever change their life circumstances**. Whether they deserved it or not, an upper caste person would always have high status, while a lower caste person would always be of low status.
- Theoretically, the Caste system can be understood as the combination of two sets of principles, one based on **difference and separation** and the other on **holism and hierarchy**.
- Each caste is supposed to be different from – and is therefore strictly separated from every other caste. Many of the **scriptural rules of caste are thus designed to prevent the mixing of castes** – rules ranging from marriage, food sharing and social interaction to occupation.
- On the other hand, these different and separated castes do not have an individual existence – they can only exist in relation to a larger whole, the totality of society consisting of all castes.
- Further, this societal whole or system is **hierarchical** rather than an egalitarian system.
- Each individual caste occupies not just a distinct place, but also an **ordered rank** – a particular position in a **ladder-like arrangement** going from highest to lowest.

Caste and Hierarchy

- _____ described the ritual rankings that exist within the Jati system as being based on the concepts of religious purity and pollution.
- The hierarchical ordering of castes is **based on the distinction between 'purity' and 'pollution'**. This is a division between something believed to be closer to the sacred (thus connoting ritual purity), and something believed to be distant from or opposed to the sacred, therefore considered ritually polluting.
- Castes that are considered **ritually pure have high status**, while those considered less pure or impure have low status.
- As in all societies, material power (i.e., economic or military power) is closely associated with social status, so that those **in power tend to be of high status, and vice versa**. Historians believe that those who were defeated in wars were often assigned low caste status.
- Finally, castes are not only **unequal** to each other in ritual terms, they are also supposed to be **complementary and non-competing groups**.
- In other words, each caste has its **own place** in the system which cannot be taken by any other caste.
- Since caste is also linked with **occupation**, the system functions as the **social division of labour**, except that, in principle, it allows no mobility.

How does caste work?

- For centuries, caste has dictated almost every aspect of Hindu religious and social life, with each group occupying a **specific place in this complex hierarchy**.
- Rural communities have long been arranged on the basis of castes – the upper and lower castes almost always lived in **segregated colonies**, the **water wells** were not shared, Brahmins would not **accept food or drink** from the Shudras, and one **could marry only within one's caste**.
- The system bestowed many privileges on the upper castes while sanctioning **repression** of the lower castes by privileged groups.
- Often criticised for being **unjust** and **regressive**, it remained virtually unchanged for centuries, trapping people into **fixed social orders** from which it was impossible to escape.



- Despite the obstacles, however, some Dalits and other low-caste Indians, such as **BR Ambedkar** who authored the Indian constitution, and **KR Narayanan** who became the nation's first Dalit president, have risen to hold **prestigious positions** in the country.
- Historians, though, say that until the 18th Century, the formal distinctions of caste were of limited importance to Indians, social identities were much more flexible and people could move easily from one caste to another.

In summary, caste in India is a complex social system with theoretical underpinnings grounded in principles of difference, hierarchy, and ritual purity. Its functioning involves the strict segregation of castes, hierarchical order, and limitations on mobility, shaping the socio-religious fabric of India for centuries.

Paper 2 – Chapter 3.2

CASTE MOBILITY

Caste mobility is not a new phenomenon, it has been prevalent in society for many centuries. Caste mobility refers to the process where the **members of lower caste try to raise their social status in the caste hierarchy** and also the **caste as a group attempts mobility** by gaining political power or through the process of **politicization of castes**.

To understand the process of caste mobility, many scholars have come up with theories based on their own understanding.

1. _____ has talked about social mobility in India through **renunciation**, where the lower castes tried to perform the acts of sannyasins in order to increase their social value and to escape the deprivation of their own place in social hierarchy.
2. _____, through his studies of **Sanskritization and Westernization**, explained the Caste mobility.

Types of Caste Mobility:

1. Mobility through warfare
2. Mobility through serving rulers
3. Mobility through census commissioners at different levels
4. Mobility through sanskritization and westernization
5. Mobility by use of politics

1. Mobility through warfare:

_____ has referred to caste mobility through warfare in the Mughal period. According to her, the most effective way to rise in the Caste hierarchy is by the acquisition of territory either through **conquest or by peaceful occupancy of sparsely populated or empty land**.

_____ gave an example of **Shivaji** (Maratha King – Sudra varna) in Mughal period who **overthrew Mughal rule** and established Maratha empire and went through the religious rites of transition into **Kshatriyahood**. Along with Shivaji's rise in his caste, the marathas as a whole became Kshatriyas.

2. Mobility through serving rulers:

Jatis, whose members served either **Hindu or non-Hindu castes, acquired higher Varna rank**.

Example: **Patidars of Gujarat**, an efficient group of Shudra Varna, supported Maratha descendants of Shivaji(Gaekwads)who ruled central Gujarat. Gradually, claiming to be kshatriyas, they established their own regimes.

3. Mobility through census commissioners:

While recording jati identities in census enumerations from 1891 to 1931, many middle and low castes made efforts to get themselves **registered as members of twice-born castes**. **Herbert Risley**, the census commissioner tried to rank all castes.Hundreds of jatis tried to get ranked high, by claiming their Varna titles.

Example: Kurmi cultivators of Bengal wanted to be Kurmi Kshatriyas, Teli (oil pressers) wanted to be called vaishyas.

4. Mobility through sanskritization and westernization:

M.N.Srinivas in 1952, through the process of Sanskritization and westernization, explained caste mobility.

Sanskritization is a process by which a **low caste** was able to rise in **a generation or two** to a **higher position** in the hierarchy by adopting **Vegetarianism and Teetotalism**. They take over rituals, customs, rites and beliefs of the brahmins and give up their own practices which might be considered to be **impure**.

Westernization is the process of emulating the western cultures by adopting ideology, values, institutions and technology as a result of cultural contact with western society for a long period. The important feature of westernization is **emphasis on technology and rationalism**.

5. Mobility by use of politics:

Several castes have used **politics in their attempt to better their condition or to achieve their goals**. Use of politics, according to _____, covers securing governmental benefits and representation in **legislative and political bodies**.

Example: Mahars of Maharashtra, Reddys and Kammas of Andhra Pradesh.



Mahars with the help of military service not only claimed a higher position in social hierarchy but also exposed themselves to the Western culture.

Some other scholars like _____ have given examples of some middle and lower castes and economically deprived communities in **Gujarat** who formed some organizations in **1940s and 1950s for achieving political power**. After winning elections against Congress, they were accepted into the kshatriya fold.

Factors Responsible for Caste Mobility:

1. Decline of the Jajmani System

The traditional jajmani system tied lower castes to hereditary occupations and ritual services for upper castes. With its decline due to monetization of the economy, market integration, and urban migration, many service castes could break free from dependency on dominant castes. This provided opportunities to move into new occupations and achieve upward mobility.

2. Emergence of Modern Occupations (Sharma, 1974)

As industries, professions, and services expanded after colonial rule and modernization, new occupational avenues opened up that were not linked to caste background. According to Sharma (1974), entry into such jobs—teaching, administration, technical professions—allowed many lower and middle castes to improve their social status.

3. Decline of Untouchability and the Purity–Pollution Principle (Kolenda, 1986)

Pauline Kolenda (1986) highlighted that caste hierarchies were maintained by strict notions of ritual purity and pollution. With social reform movements, urbanization, and state laws, these restrictions began to weaken. The decline of untouchability practices allowed Dalits and other marginalized groups to access education, employment, and public spaces, thereby enabling upward mobility.

4. Education

Access to modern education created a pathway for marginalized castes to enter respected professions, government jobs, and leadership positions. Education also fostered social awareness, enabling oppressed groups to challenge caste-based inequalities.

5. State Policy of Protective Discrimination

Constitutional provisions like **reservation in education, government jobs, and political representation** gave Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes opportunities to achieve mobility that was historically denied. These policies acted as a structural lever for change.

6. Social Movements

Movements led by leaders like **Jyotiba Phule, Periyar, B. R. Ambedkar** and others mobilized oppressed communities against caste oppression. Dalit movements, backward caste mobilizations, and regional caste associations pushed for rights, dignity, and recognition. Such movements provided both symbolic and material bases for social mobility.

Downward Caste Mobility

1. Abolition of Zamindari and Jagirdari (Rajasthan case)

- Land reforms forced many **Rajputs, Brahmins, and Jats** (once Zamindars) into economic decline.
- Some became **manual and agricultural labourers**, a sharp fall from their earlier status.
- **Sharma** (1968, Rajasthan villages) found ex-Zamindars working alongside Dalits in famine relief works, showing drastic downward mobility.

2. Impact of Green Revolution and Agrarian Capitalism

- Mechanisation and capitalist farming led to **pauperisation of small peasants and tenants**, while rich tenants rose as capitalist farmers (Saith and Tankha, 1972).
- Thus, sections of middle and lower peasants experienced downward mobility despite technological progress.

3. Domain-specific Decline among Service Castes

- Castes like **Barbers** who gave up polluting tasks (e.g., cleaning plates) lost patronage from upper castes, splitting into sub-groups and facing economic hardships.
- Similarly, **Balais (leather workers)** discarded leather work to gain ritual status but ended up migrating as casual labourers due to loss of livelihood.

4. Failed Upward Mobility of Scheduled Castes

- **Regars (leather workers)** in Rajasthan, Haryana, and Western UP attempted to renounce leather work (1971–72).
- They faced harassment from dominant Jats and severe livelihood insecurity, forcing many to revert to their traditional occupation within months.

5. Withdrawal of Status Respect (Jagirdars)

- Post-abolition, **Jagirdars in Rajasthan** lost not only land but also political clout.



- Some withdrew completely from Panchayat politics due to the humiliation of competing with lower castes, marking a decline in both social and political domains.

Caste mobility in India shows that the caste system, though rigid, has never been completely static. Communities have moved upward through warfare, service to rulers, Sanskritisation, Westernisation, census claims, and politics, while modern factors like education, social movements, and state policies further enabled mobility. At the same time, structural changes like land reforms and the Green Revolution also pushed some castes downward. Thus, caste mobility is a **two-way process shaped by history, economy, politics, and culture**, making it central to understanding Indian society.

THEORIES OF ORIGIN OF CASTE

There are many theories that were put forward to explain the origin of the caste system in India, but none of them gained universal acceptance. Few of such theories are

1. Traditional Theory
2. Brahmanical Theory
3. Racial Theory
4. Occupational Theory
5. Ketkar Theory
6. Senart Theory
7. Hutton's Theory

1. TRADITIONAL THEORY:

- Many scholars describe hindu society as a **supernatural-centered society** in which people are lured by abstract truth, and search for it through mysticism and not through science.
- The traditional theory believes that the **caste system has been established by divine ordinance** or at least with divine approval.
- This theory has two versions
 - a. Mythical theory
 - b. Metaphysical theory
- MYTHICAL theory:**
 - The mythical version regards **four varnas as four castes** and believes that these **four 'castes' have emerged from different parts of Brahma's body.**
 - A man is born in a particular caste because of his actions performed in his previous incarnation.** That is, birth in a particular caste is not an accident.
- METAPHYSICAL VERSION:**
 - Explains that each **caste has a separate function and this function** is determined by the **nature (swabhav)** and the **qualities (guna)** of the caste members.
 - Eg:** If a person is born to rule, he becomes part of Kshatriyas.
- Criticism:**
 - The traditional theory of the origin of caste has been **rejected by the scholars mainly because of two reasons:**
 - one, it considers caste as a natural phenomenon;
 - two, it considers four varnas as four castes.
 - Referring to this, **M.N. Srinivas** says that the idea of caste as the four fold division of society represents the **gross oversimplification of facts**, the **real unit** of caste system is **jati**.

2. BRAHMANICAL THEORY:

- Abbe Dubois** feels that the caste system **originated and developed in India because of Brahmins.**
- He maintains that the caste system is an **ingenious device made by Brahmins for Brahmins.**
- Brahmins impose restrictions** on eating and drinking, marriage, and social relations with non-Brahmins **to preserve their purity .**
- At the same time, they gave themselves a **high status and special privileges** and prerogatives in the Brahmana and other books and declared all others as inferior to them.
- Ghurye also agrees** that caste-society was the result of the attempts by Brahmanic civilization to exclude the aborigines and the Sudras from religious and social communion with themselves.
- Criticism:**

_____ argues **against** it:

1. If this theory is accepted, it would mean that **caste must have originated at a date when Brahmins must have got the political power** and he thinks that **caste did not originate so late.**



3. RACIAL THEORY:

- According to **Risley**, the **clash of cultures and the contact of races** crystallized castes in India.
- He says that the migrant **Aryans had their own ideas of ceremonial purity**. They **considered the original inhabitants as inferior** to them.
- Besides, the **Aryans were essentially patrilineal in nature** while the **local population whom they conquered were matrilineal**. They, therefore, married the daughters of the **aboriginals but refused to give their daughters to them**.
- The **children of "irregular union" had to be assigned the lowest position** in the society and were **called the chandalas**.
- Thus, the **origin of the group of 'half-breeds'** as well as the **feeling of racial superiority** ultimately became **responsible for the origin of the caste system**.

Risley has referred to **six processes in the formation of castes**:

- (i) Change in traditional occupation:** By **adopting a new occupation**, either a caste or a sub-division of a caste ultimately develops into a distinct caste.
- (ii) Migration:** In early periods when the means of transport and communications were not fully developed, whenever a section of a **caste migrated to other region, it became difficult for it to maintain contacts with the parental caste**. Gradually, therefore, it was **completely cut off from the parental caste and developed as a new caste**.
- (iii) Change in customs:** The formation of **new castes as a consequence of discarding old customs and usages and by adopting the new practices** has been a familiar incident of the caste system from the earliest times.
- (iv) Preservation of old traditions:** **Certain castes cherish the traditions and preserve old traces** of an organization. To **separate themselves from those sections who have assumed new traditions and customs, they take up a new name and thus a new caste** comes into existence.
- (v) Enrolling oneself into the rank of Hinduism:** Sometimes either **an entire tribe or a section of a tribe becomes 'Hinduised' and taking a new caste name**, it enters into the rank of Hinduism and distinguishes itself from the other castes; for example, Maria Gonds of Madhya Pradesh and Rajbanshis of Bengal.
- (vi) Role of religious enthusiasts:** A **religious enthusiast sometimes preaches his own doctrines** and his followers form a separate sect which **ultimately develops as a new caste**.

CRITICISM :

- If Risley's racial theory is to be accepted, it would **mean that the caste system should not be confined to India but should be found in all those societies** which have faced conquests by other racial groups.
- Therefore, to analyze the scientific explanation of Risley's theory, we have to take up the question whether caste is a unique Indian phenomenon or not

4. OCCUPATIONAL THEORY:

- **Nesfield** says that the origin of caste has nothing to do with racial affinity or religion but it is **mainly due to functions or occupations**.
- Nesfield says that the **technical skill of the occupation was passed on hereditary from generation to generation** and because of practicing the same occupation over a long period of time, **'occupational guilds'** came into existence which **later on came to be known as castes**.
- The hierarchy in the caste system, according to him, was the result of the feeling of the superiority and inferiority of occupations.
- **CRITICISM:**
 - _____ has also criticized Nesfield's idea of the hierarchy of castes in terms of the **superiority or the inferiority of the occupations**.
 - He maintains that the **status of castes depends not on the superiority or the inferiority of occupation but upon the degree of purity of blood** and the extent of isolation maintained by the groups.

5. KETKAR'S THEORY :

- Ketkar **traces the origin of castes from the early tribes**, where each of the tribe group was **endogamous** and was **hostile to other tribes** for resources.
- He believes that **castes are 'developed tribes' or converted groups**.
- **CRITICISM:**
 - Accepting the origin of castes from tribes **would mean accepting the fact that the caste system was evolved not by the Aryans** but by the native Dravidians or aborigines.
 - History can definitely be cited as proof that the caste system did not exist in pre-vedic period but it evolved only in the post-vedic period, that is, tribals in the pre-Vedic period can under no circumstances be held responsible for the creation of castes.

6. SENART'S THEORY:

- Senart (Caste in India, 1930) traces the **origin of the caste system to the Aryan sources**.
- **Indians, Greek and Romans are all Aryans** and their civilizations are the oldest ones. Senart finds **certain similarities in the three systems**.



- As we have three important groups, namely, **family, gotra and caste in India, we have gens, curia and tribe in Rome; and family, phratia and phyle in Greece.**
- And also, **just as caste panchayats exist in India and its head (sarpanch) is an all powerful man, in Rome and Greece too there are similar councils with similar powers.**
- On the basis of such comparisons, Senart maintains that caste developed as a natural course of development of these ancient Aryan institutions.
- **Criticism:**
 - _____ main arguments against Senart's theory are that:
 - The **origin of caste cannot be explained only in terms of certain elements.** Such a complex institution must be the result of **multiple forces.**

7. HUTTON'S THEORY OF MANA:

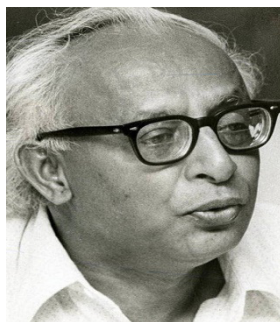
- **Hutton (1961)** has emphasized on the "primitive" conception of mana in the formation of castes
- Mana is a **mysterious impersonal power** attached to individuals, objects and places.
- **Taboos** were, therefore, imposed on commensality, inter-marriage and interaction, etc. **to save the members of one's tribe from the mana of the other tribes.**
- The **restriction on sharing food** with others and having contacts with them is based on the **belief that these (food and contacts) may be infected with the dangerous mana.**
- In his **study of Nagas in 1923-24**, Hutton found **villagers objected to accepting presents or money from strangers for fear of the influence of the mana attached to those objects.**
- **Criticism:**
 - _____ (1952) has criticized Hutton's explanation of caste in terms of mana. He maintains that though tribes in other societies also **believe in mana but we do not find a caste system there.**
 - He considers caste as an outcome of interaction of a number of geographical, social, political, religious and economic factors.

Conclusion:

Scholars like _____ supported the **Multifactor Theory**, arguing that several factors working together over time led to the emergence of the Indian caste system. In essence, the caste system is a **complex and multifaceted social phenomenon**, shaped by religious, cultural, economic, and political influences. Its origins cannot be traced to a single factor or event, but are the outcome of a long and layered historical process, highlighting the need for a nuanced understanding of its evolution and its implications for contemporary Indian society.

DOMINANT CASTE

The concept of dominant caste was given by **M.N Srinivas** in his path-breaking research paper "**Dominant Caste in Rampura**". It gave us a new insight about the process of social change in India. '**Dominant Caste**' is a term used to refer to those castes which had a large population and were granted land rights by the partial land reforms that came into effect after Independence. The land reforms took away rights from the erstwhile claimants, the upper castes who were '**absentee landlords**' in the sense that they played no part in the agricultural economy other than claiming their rent.



M.N. Srinivas



Characteristics of a dominant caste as given by Srinivas:

- It must own a **sizable amount of cultivable land**.
 - Owning a sizable amount of cultivable land can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by providing them with economic resources and control over agricultural production, which can translate into political and social power.
- It must be of **considerable numerical strength**.
 - Considerable numerical strength can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by giving them a large voting bloc and the ability to mobilize resources and influence public opinion.
- It must enjoy a **reasonably high place in the local caste hierarchy**.
 - Enjoying a reasonably high place in the local caste hierarchy can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by giving them social prestige and cultural capital, which can translate into economic and political power as well as control over social norms and values.

How are the criteria for dominant caste changing?

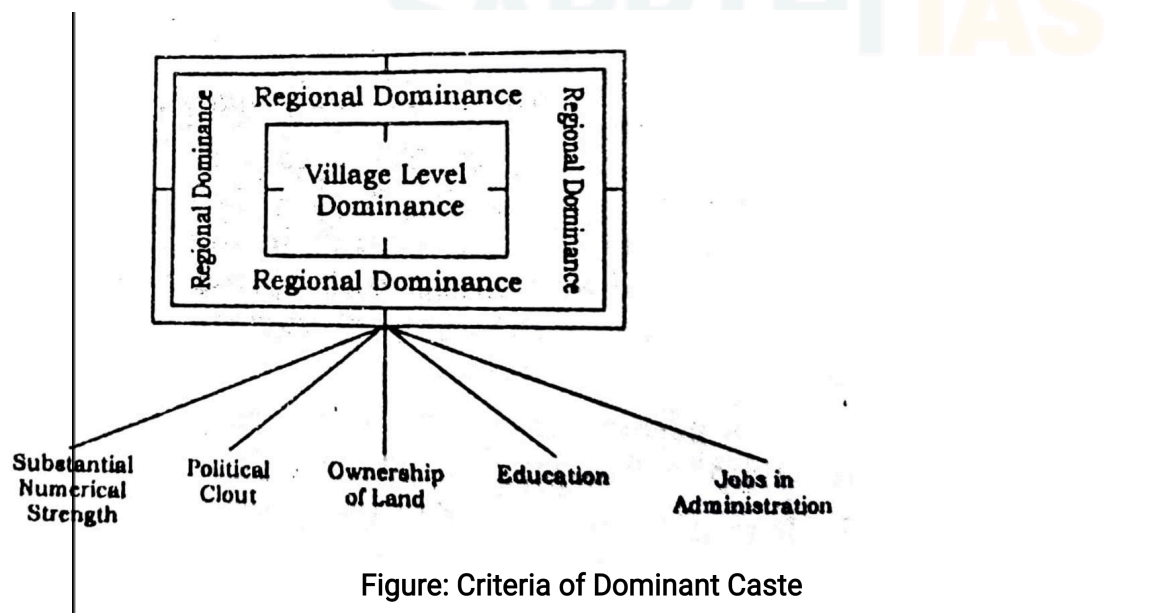
Mere ownership of land, numerical strength and high place in ritual hierarchy are no longer the only determining factors. Now western education, jobs in administration, and political clout and contacts are the new and additional features. The introduction of adult franchise, democratic decentralization, reservation and spread of education among the depressed has further changed the criteria for dominant caste.

So the new characteristics:

- **Political Clout**
 - Political clout can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by allowing them to control the decision-making process and access to resources, leading to greater economic and social power.
- **Western Education**
 - Western education can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by providing them with skills and knowledge that are valued in modern society, which can lead to greater economic opportunities and social mobility.
- **Jobs in Administration**
 - Jobs in administration can contribute to a caste becoming the dominant caste by providing them with access to positions of power and influence, allowing them to control important aspects of society such as law enforcement, public policy, and governance.

Village level dominance and regional level dominance:

Due to expansion in transport and communication, village level dominance is no longer enough to make a caste dominant. Instead, **regional level dominance** seems to be a better criterion.



Examples of Dominant Castes: Srinivas says that the existence of dominant caste is not particular to just Rampura. It is found in other villages of the country also. For instance:

- in Mysore villages, **Lingayat and Okkaliga**;
- in Andhra Pradesh, **Reddy and Kamma**;
- in Tamilnadu, **Gounder, Padayachi and Mudaliar**;
- in Kerala, **Nair**;

- in Maharashtra, **Maratha**;
- in Gujarat, **Patidar**; and
- In northern India, **Rajput, Jat, Giyar and Ahir** are dominant castes.

Dominant caste and Sanskritization :

Sanskritization for lower castes is not always Brahmins, it is the Dominant Caste that lower castes try to emulate and climb up the social ladder.

For instance

- In certain areas of eastern Uttar Pradesh the dominant **Thakur landlords** make the Brahmins cook food except their *kulguru* (family priest)
- Similarly, in many Punjab villages, Jat landlords view Brahmins as their servants, reflecting the emulation of Jats in this context.

Role of Dominant Caste in Culture Preservation:

The Dominant Caste usually keeps its distance **from others in the village and the whole region of dominance**. It considers itself as the protector and watchdog of culture. It **sets certain norms of behaviour**, the violation of which is dealt severely.

Dominant Caste and Dispute Settlement:

Dominant Castes **settle the disputes** through the traditional village and caste councils. They not only settle the disputes among the members of different castes but also among the members of their own caste.

Relevance / Contemporary Significance of Dominant Caste

1. Political Mobilization and Electoral Power

- With adult franchise and Panchayati Raj, numerical strength of dominant castes has become central to politics.
- Example: *Yadavs in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh* transformed their demographic weight into political dominance through leaders like Lalu Prasad Yadav and Mulayam Singh Yadav.
- Scholars like _____ show how dominant OBC castes act as "vote banks" shaping regional parties (e.g., RJD, SP).

2. Cultural Hegemony and Emulation

- Dominant castes remain cultural models for lower castes. Srinivas noted that Sanskritization often targets the lifestyle of dominant regional groups, not just Brahmins.
- Example: *Jats in Punjab* or *Thakurs in UP* being emulated by lower castes in rituals, food practices, and marriage customs.

3. Erosion and Contestation

- Dominance is increasingly challenged by SC/ST assertion, reservations, and social movements. For instance, Dalit movements in Maharashtra (Ambedkarite mobilization) and the rise of BSP in UP disrupted traditional dominance of Marathas and Thakurs.
- Still, dominant castes adapt by forming alliances or repositioning within party politics.

4. Changing Basis of Dominance: Beyond Land

- Andre Beteille (2003) observed that dominance is no longer tied only to land. Access to *education, bureaucracy, and political networks* is now crucial.
- Example: *Lingayats in Karnataka* and *Reddys in Andhra Pradesh* dominate through educational institutions and political representation, not just agriculture.

Criticism / Limitations of Dominant Caste

1. Dominant Individuals vs Dominant Caste:

- _____ argued that dominance is often held by *individuals or factions* within a caste rather than by the caste as a whole.
- Dube emphasized that calling an entire caste dominant only makes sense if power is shared widely and exercised for the benefit of most members. In reality, inequalities of wealth and prestige exist within so-called dominant castes. For example, dominant individuals often exploit weaker members of their own caste along with members of other castes.

■ Srinivas's Response to Critics:

- Srinivas accepted that there are dominant individuals and factions but argued that their influence derives from belonging to a dominant caste.
- In his words, "dominant individuals and dominant factions owe their dominance to the fact they are part of the dominant caste." Thus, individual or factional dominance cannot be separated from caste identity.

2. Changing Basis of Dominance

- _____'s study of *Mohana* village (Uttar Pradesh, 1958) showed that Brahmins and Thakurs were dominant due to *zamindari*. But after abolition of zamindari, Thakur dominance weakened though they retained some power through moneylending.



- This shows that dominance based purely on land is not permanent. With land reforms, political power and new economic bases became more important.

3. Numerical Strength not Decisive

- Majumdar argued that numerical size alone does not ensure dominance. For example, in many villages the Scheduled Castes (like Lodha or Pasi in UP) may be numerically largest, but authority still rested with a few upper-caste landlord families.
- On the other hand, scholars like _____ emphasized that under adult suffrage, numerical strength became crucial for political dominance, especially for SCs and STs with reserved seats.

In conclusion, the concept of **dominant caste**, introduced by **M. N. Srinivas**, has been significant in anthropology as it helps in understanding the **social hierarchies and power dynamics** in Indian society. It has been applied to study **caste-based social stratification** and the role of caste in shaping **political and economic relationships** in villages. In contemporary Indian villages, the relevance of the dominant caste concept can still be seen, as it continues to influence the **social and political life** of people. For instance, in many villages, dominant castes continue to **control local politics and hold economic power**, while lower castes face **discrimination and marginalization**. Therefore, the concept of dominant caste remains **highly relevant** in understanding the **complex social realities** of Indian villages.

3.2. FUTURE OF CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA

The caste system, one of the oldest forms of social stratification, has historically shaped India's **social, economic, and political life**. Reformers like Gandhi and Ambedkar envisioned either its reform or abolition, yet caste continues to persist in both overt and subtle ways. As **M. N. Srinivas** observed, caste adapts through processes like **Sanskritisation** and **Westernisation** rather than disappearing. The future of caste, therefore, can best be seen as a tension between **persistence** and **transformation**.

1. Present Reality of Caste

Caste shows little sign of weakening. Castes today seek **upward mobility** by forming associations such as the All India Brahmin Association or the All India Yadav Association, which function as pressure groups for **jobs, education, and political influence**. Caste identity remains a key basis for **social organisation** and **political mobilisation**.

Counter-view: In urban contexts and high-skill sectors like IT, hiring often values **merit** over caste. Studies (e.g., Banerjee) show limited caste bias in software jobs when qualifications are equal. Organisations like **DICCI** (Dalit Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry) represent new forms of Dalit assertion through **entrepreneurship**.

2. Reformist and Abolitionist Approaches

Two major ideological strands have shaped discourse on caste:

- **Reformist View:** _____ argued for a **purified varna system**, where duties were based on qualities, not birth. Yet, scholars note that such a revival is impractical in a **modern economy** with highly specialised occupations.
- **Abolitionist View:** _____ saw caste as inherently **oppressive** and demanded its destruction. Ambedkar in *Annihilation of Caste* declared that "*political democracy cannot last unless social democracy is achieved.*" Despite safeguards, casteism persists.

Counter-view: Alternative traditions exist. The **Lingayat movement** rejected caste hierarchy outright. Modern trends like **Dalit Capitalism** (Chandra Bhan Prasad) emphasise entrepreneurship as a tool for social dignity, showing that caste hierarchies can also be challenged through **economic means**.

3. Remedies Suggested

According to a survey by _____ (1957) (based on 1,225 respondents), the most effective remedies for weakening caste hierarchies were identified as:

- **Expanding education and economic opportunities** (39.1%), which can reduce dependence on traditional caste-based occupations.
- **Promoting inter-caste marriages** (35.3%), to directly challenge endogamy and foster social integration.
- **Removing untouchability in practice** (12.2%), through both legal enforcement and social reform.
- **Ensuring equality of treatment in everyday life** (13.4%), to gradually erode caste prejudice in social interactions.

Counter-view: Education has indeed reduced some gaps. Economists **Hnatkovska and Lahiri (2012)** documented convergence in education and wages for SCs/STs from the 1980s to 2010s. Inter-caste marriages, while only 5% nationally (IHDS-2, 2011-12), are slowly rising in urban areas, and **NFHS-5 data** links them to better child nutrition. Attitudes remain rigid (Pew Survey 2021), yet younger and urban Indians show more openness.



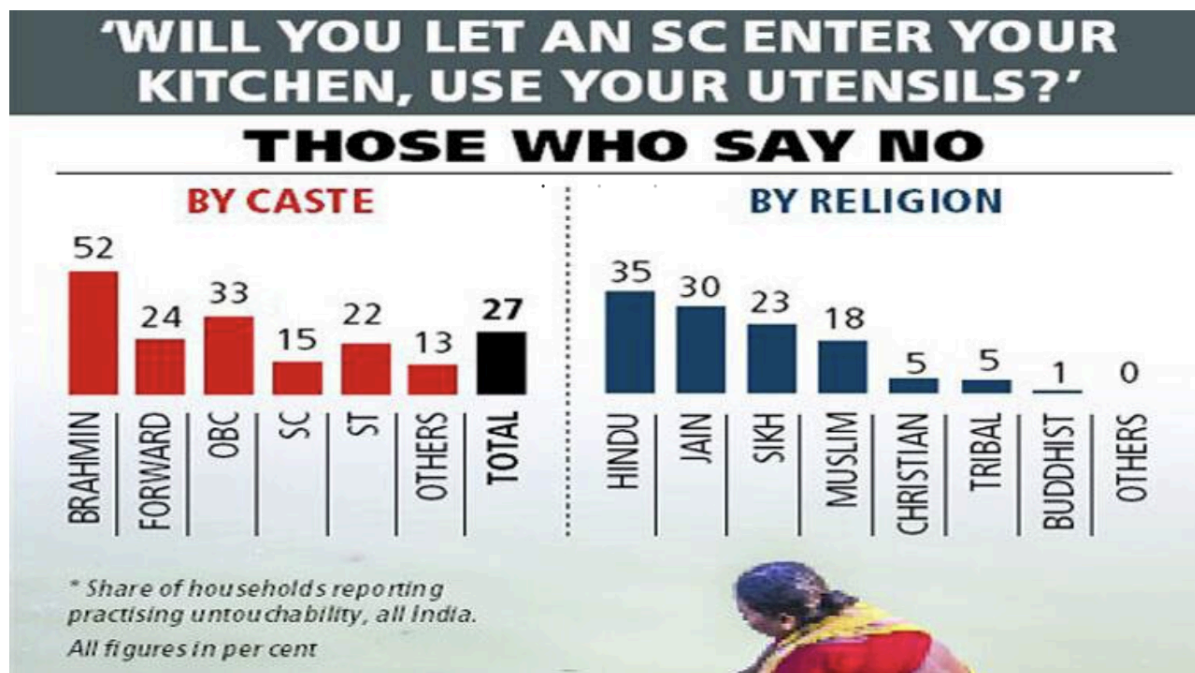
4. Obstacles and Political Reinforcement

The Supreme Court's **Mandal verdict (1992)** upheld caste as the basis for reservations, affirming its salience in **public policy**. Pauline Kolenda (1997) observed that a system shaping Indian society for over 1,000 years cannot vanish within decades. Politics continues to reinforce caste identity, as **electoral mobilisation** remains deeply caste-based.

Counter-view: Incremental changes are visible. The **EWS quota (2019)** introduced economic criteria, loosening caste as the sole axis of affirmative action. Recent **caste surveys** (e.g., Bihar 2023) provide nuanced socio-economic data, helping rethink welfare policies. Christophe Jaffrelot argues that caste politics has also **empowered marginalised groups**, enabling new forms of bargaining power.

5. Persistence of Caste Practices

- **Endogamy:** Despite legal freedom, only 5% of marriages are inter-caste. Caste remains the **primary criterion** in matrimonial alliances.
- **Untouchability:** A large survey (NCAER & University of Maryland) shows that **27% of India still practices untouchability**. More than one in four people face it.



Source: The India Human Development Survey (IHDS-2)

- **Hereditary occupations:** Certain jobs remain heavily caste-linked.
 - **Uttar Pradesh:** Out of 46,000 leather workers, 41,000 are from Chamars, Dhusia, and Jatava castes. Among SC sweepers aged 35-59, 63.4% are Balmikis, and among 15-34, 62% are Balmikis (showing little generational change). For leather work in the 35-59 group, 88.2% are Chamars, Dhusias, and Jatavas.
 - **Rajasthan:** Out of 76,000 sweepers, almost 52,000 are Bhangi, Mehtar, and Chura. A similar pattern holds in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.

Counter-view: Endogamy is weakening slightly among the educated and urban youth, with inter-caste unions increasing through modern matrimonial platforms. **Untouchability** is directly challenged by laws such as the **Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers Act (2013)** and schemes like **NAMASTE (2022)** which mechanise sanitation work. Technological modernisation in occupations further erodes caste-based job divisions.

Conclusion

The evidence suggests that **caste will remain a significant social reality** in India's foreseeable future. Its persistence is ensured by **endogamy, caste-based politics, and entrenched social attitudes**. At the same time, caste is also undergoing **transformation**: it is less about ritual hierarchy and more about **identity, politics, and access to resources**. Thus, the future of caste is not its disappearance but its **persistence in new forms**. The challenge is to ensure that caste identities do not translate into **caste inequalities**. As **Andre Beteille** notes, the tension between **caste and class** will define India's social structure, while the state and civil society must continue to work towards **reducing inequities** sustained by caste.

3.4- Impact of various religions on Indian society

India is known for its diversity. It is a home to many religions Hinduism, Islam, Buddhism, Jainism, Christianity, Zoroastrianism. Since all of them were living together, they had certain influences on each other and influenced the Indian society as a whole. So let us take a look at how each religion impacted the various spheres of life of Indian society.

Impact of Buddhism on Indian society:

Indian society at the time of Buddha was **static, hierarchical, and dominated by rituals and sacrifices**. Ascribed status was given primacy over achieved status, and conditions were particularly harsh for women, shudras, and some vaishyas. Buddhism emerged in response to these conditions, rejecting caste divisions, ritual sacrifices, and priestly monopoly, while preaching **equality, ethics, and intellectual freedom**.

The essence of Buddhism:

Buddhism preached the noble Eightfold path. It includes:

1. Right Understanding
2. Right Thought
3. Right Speech
4. Right Action
5. Right Livelihood
6. Right Effort
7. Right Mindfulness
8. Right Concentration.

• **Social life:**

Situation prevalent at the time of Buddha:

- Ascribed status was given primacy over achieved status.
- Situations were very bad for women, shudra, and some vaishya,

• **Egalitarianism:**

- Buddhism rejected the varna system and declared that **anyone could join the Sangha**, irrespective of caste or gender.
- _____ notes that this shift encouraged recognition of achieved status over birth-based status, especially in early urban centres.

○ **Status of Women**

- Women were allowed to become nuns and pursue education and spiritual life.
- _____ highlights that works like the *Therigatha* show how early Buddhist nuns expressed intellectual and spiritual autonomy, marking a significant step in gender empowerment.

• **Ethics and morality, code of conduct:**

- Buddhism offered a **code of conduct** that emphasised truth, non-violence, compassion, and restraint from theft or alcohol.
- _____ observed that these principles acted as **civic ethics**, a new form of social control beyond ritual sanction.

• **Religious life:**

- Buddhism provided an alternative to elaborate sacrifices and priestly domination.

• **Intellectual freedom:**

- Logic replaced superstition. This encouraged them to think for oneself.
- It enabled them to question the rituals and dogma because it is written in the local understandable language of Pali, but not in Sanskrit.
- _____ notes that the Pali canon emphasised reasoned inquiry, making debate and questioning the default mode of religious learning.

○ **Literature:**

- **Pali Canon (Tipitaka)** preserved the earliest teachings.
- Jataka tales narrated Buddha's earlier births, often with moral lessons.
- Works like the *Therigatha* reflected women's voices.
- Apabhramsa writings of Buddhism and Jainism enriched Indian linguistic traditions.

• **Education:**

- Most of the ancient India's Universities like **Nalanda, Vikramshila, Taxila, Valabhi** are products of Buddhism.
- **R. C. Majumdar** adds that at Taxila, Buddhist and non-Buddhist subjects like law, medicine, and grammar coexisted, showing the broad scope of education.



- **Art and architecture:**
 - _____ highlights the **Gandhara and Mathura schools of art**, which flourished due to Buddhist patronage and reflected the blending of local and foreign artistic influences.
 - **Ashoka pillars** in Bihar and UP are from this period.
 - **Stupas** at **Sanchi, Sarnath, Nalanda** are some of the architectural marvels.
 - Figurines at Kanheri, Karle, Nasik etc.. are seen during this period.
 - Sculptures at **Barabar, Ajanta** are regarded as masterpieces of Buddhist religious art.
 - Paintings like Ajanta, Ellora got universal attention.
 - Carvings on railings and gates of stupas represented events from the historic life of the Buddha.
- **Economic life:**
 - Buddhism opposed animal sacrifice, encouraged agriculture, and sanctified the cow.
 - Monasteries became nodes of economic life.
 - _____ points out that monasteries were often located along trade routes, acting as hubs of commerce and exchange.
 - _____ noted that monasteries provided social services, distributing food and medical care, enhancing welfare functions.
- **Political life:**
 - **Welfare:**
 - Vaishya and Shudra who were looked down upon within the hindu fold converted in large numbers.
 - Those who were not of 'any concern' to a large number of rulers in the past, now their welfare was taken up.
 - **Romila Thapar** argues that Ashoka's dhamma was not a creed but a model of **ethical kingship**, emphasising welfare and moral governance.
 - **Non-violence:**
 - This message was reverberating post kalinga war when it was carved in pillars, and spread through dharma mahamatras.
 - **Decline in military strength:**
 - Emphasis on non-aggression, non-violence, ascetic life, spiritualism weakened the militancy of Indians and caused decline in military strength of India.
 - India fell easy prey to foreign invaders who came in quick succession to centuries of political subjugation.

Negative Impact of Buddhism:

- **Decline of Vedic Ritual Economy:**
 - **R. S. Sharma** points out that Buddhism's rejection of elaborate Vedic sacrifices reduced the importance of priests in the ritual economy, which weakened the traditional Brahmanical order and created tensions with orthodox groups.
- **Monastic Withdrawal from Society:**
 - **Romila Thapar** observes that the growth of Buddhist monasteries sometimes led to **economic withdrawal** from productive activities, as monks depended on lay donations. This could strain agrarian communities and limit wider participation in economic life.

Spread:

- **Outside India:**
 - Ashoka: Buddhism was spread by Ashoka through dhamma mahamatras.
 - According to **Mahavamsa** in the 17th year of Ashoka's reign, at the end of 3rd Buddhist council, Ashoka sent buddhist missionaries to 9 parts of the world to propagate Buddhism.
 - He sent his only daughter **Sanghamitra** and son **Mahindra** to spread Buddhism in Srilanka.
 - **India:** almost died out
 - Indian Buddhism, having become primarily a monastic movement, seemed to lose touch with its lay supporters. Many **monasteries had become very wealthy**, so much so that they were able to **employ indentured slaves and paid labourers to care for the monks** and to tend the lands they owned. Thus, after the Muslim invaders sacked the Indian monasteries in the 12th and 13th centuries, there wasn't a revival since then until the 20th century.
 - Why the 20th century?
 - The **modern revival of Buddhism** in India began in the late nineteenth century, led by Buddhist modernist institutions such as the **Maha Bodhi Society** (1891), the **Bengal Buddhist Association** (1892) and the **Young Men's Buddhist Association** (1898).
 - In the 1950s, the Dalit political leader **B. R. Ambedkar** (1891-1956), influenced by his reading of Pali sources and Indian Buddhists like **Dharmapala and Kosambi** and **Lakshmi Narasu**, began **promoting conversion to Buddhism for Indian low caste Dalits**.



- His Dalit Buddhist Movement was most successful in the Indian states of **Maharashtra**, which saw large scale conversions.
- Ambedkar's "**Neo Buddhism**" included a strong element of social and political protest against Hinduism and the Indian caste system

Buddhism reshaped Indian society by challenging **caste hierarchies**, promoting **equality, intellectual freedom, and moral governance**, while leaving a rich legacy in **education, art, and architecture**. Though it declined as an organised religion within India, its **values** and **cultural contributions** continue to influence Indian **thought** and **social reform** even today.

Impact of Jainism on Indian society:

Jainism, one of the oldest sramaṇa traditions, emerged in the 6th century BCE alongside Buddhism as a movement questioning Vedic orthodoxy. Its emphasis on **ahimsa, austerity, and spiritual discipline** has left a deep and lasting imprint on Indian society.

Essence of Jainism:

In Jainism the three jewels (also referred to as ratnatraya) are understood as

1. Samyak Darshan ("**right faith**")
2. Samyak Jnana ("**right knowledge**")
3. Samyak Charitra ("**right conduct**").

One of the three cannot exist exclusive of the others, and all are required for spiritual liberation.

The Five Maha-vratas (Great Vows) of Ascetics:

Right knowledge, right faith, and right conduct are the three most essentials for attaining liberation in Jainism. In order to acquire these, one must observe the **five great vows**:

1. Non-violence – Ahimsa
2. Truth – Satya
3. Non-stealing – Achaurya or Asteya
4. Non-attachment/Non-possession – Aparigraha
5. Celibacy/Chastity – Brahmacharya

• **Social Equality:**

- Jainism **rejects the caste system** and advocates for **equality**. Monastic communities do not discriminate.
- _____ observes that such sectarian movements **challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy** and offered **parallel paths of dignity**..

• **Ethical Values and Non-Violence (Ahimsa):**

- Jainism places a strong emphasis on the principle of non-violence (ahimsa). This concept has significantly influenced Indian society by promoting compassion and respect for all living beings.
- **Example:** Many Jains adhere to a **vegetarian lifestyle**, avoiding harm to animals, and engage in charitable activities to support non-violence.
- _____ highlighted Jain **ascetic ideals** of **restraint** and **compassion** as one of the strongest **moral vocabularies** of ancient India.

• **Language:** Jainism, designed for accessibility to the common people, contributed to the evolution of the **Prakrit language** through its teachings and dissemination. **Romila Thapar** emphasises that this widened the **reading public** and **democratised learning**.

• **Social Welfare Initiatives:**

- The construction of **dharamshalas**, or pilgrims' rest houses, stands as a testament to Jainism's commitment to public service.
- These dharamshalas, traditionally located near pilgrimage destinations, provide spiritual pilgrims with shelter, showcasing a practical manifestation of the Jain principles of hospitality and communal welfare.
- _____ points out that mercantile patronage made Jain temples and inns **civic hubs**.

• **Education and Scholarship:**

- Jainism has a long tradition of scholarship and education. Many Jain monks have contributed to the intellectual and educational development of Indian society.
- **Example:** Jain texts, such as the **Tattvartha Sutra**, have been instrumental in shaping philosophical discussions and intellectual pursuits in India.

• **Art and architecture:**

- **The rock cut caves:**
 - Ex: Hindu & Jain rock-cut architecture can be seen mainly at Badami, Aihole, Ajanta, Ellora, Elephanta, Aurangabad & Mamallapuram.
 - Not only is the Ellora complex a **unique artistic creation** and a technological exploit but, with its sanctuaries devoted to **Buddhism, Hinduism and Jainism**, it illustrates the **spirit of tolerance** that was characteristic of ancient India.



- **Temple construction:**
 - Ex: Jainism has left an indelible mark on temple construction, as exemplified by the iconic **Gommateshwara Bahubali statue** at **Shravanabelagola**, a revered pilgrimage destination in Jainism.
- **Paintings:**
 - **Artistic Expressions:**
 - **Eg:** The Kalpa Sutra, a manuscript containing biographies of Tirthankaras, particularly **Parshvanatha and Mahavira**, serves as a canvas for Jain artistic expressions. This illustrated text not only preserves the narrative of Jain spiritual leaders but also showcases the intricate and vibrant tradition of Jain paintings.
- **Principles of Austerity:** Jainism has significantly influenced Indian society through the promotion of virtues such as **voluntary simplicity, fasting, humility, selfless service, pursuit of knowledge, and meditation.**
- **Spread of Jainism:**
 - Jainism was not widely embraced due to its **stringent orthodoxy** and affinity to Brahmanism, as well as its non-missionary spirit and virtual absence of aggression.
 - Most of the converts were from Vaishya.
 - Jainism is India's sixth-largest religion and is practiced throughout India.
 - Per the 2011 census, there are 4,451,753 Jains in the 1.21 billion population of India, the majority living in Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh, however, **the influence of Jainism has been far greater on the Indian population and society than these numbers suggest.**
- **Criticisms and Limitations**
 - _____ pointed out that Jainism's strict commitment to **ahimsa** and ritual purity often led to **social separation and isolation** of Jain communities. While it promoted compassion, it sometimes weakened **social cohesion** with other groups.

Although Jainism remained numerically a minority faith, its **ethical values, scholarship, and cultural contributions** shaped Indian civilisation far beyond its size. The religion's legacy of **non-violence, equality, and moral restraint** continues to inspire social thought in modern India.

Impact of Islam on Indian society:

Islam entered India from the 7th century onwards through **trade, migration**, and later **political expansion**. Its presence shaped **Indian society** in multiple dimensions, from **religion and culture** to **economy, administration, and everyday social practices**.

Social and political life: Many people from deprived castes were attracted to Islam.

- The Islam impact on the constitution can be observed through the Hindu marriage act and succession act.
- Islam affected the position of Indian women where the birth of a girl is an inauspicious event. Hence this ill treatment of women is spread to Hindus.
- Writing on the socio-historical role of Islam, _____ rightly comments that **Muhammed** preached the **doctrine of one God** in polytheistic Arabia. For the concept of **one god** meant the concept of **social equality**.
- _____ an eminent historian-philosopher, has emphasised upon the message of **sulhe-kul (peace for all and complete peace)** of the Muslim Sufi Silsilah (mystic orders).

Medicine:

- Muslim introduced the **unani system of medicine** in India.
- The term Yūnānī means "Greek", as the **Perso-Arabic system of medicine** was based on the teachings of the Greek physicians Hippocrates and Galen.

Sufism:

- Sufism, mystical Islamic belief and practice in which Muslims seek the truth of divine love and knowledge through **direct personal experience of God**.
- **Richard Eaton** notes that Sufi saints often integrated local practices, producing a syncretic culture.
- Ex: Nizamuddin Auliya in Delhi. Nizamuddin Dargah is the dargah (mausoleum) of the Sufi saint Khwaja Nizamuddin Auliya (1238–1325 CE). Situated in the Nizamuddin West area of Delhi, the dargah is **visited by thousands of pilgrims every week**. The site is also known for its evening qawwali devotional music sessions. The descendants of Nizamuddin Auliya look after the whole management of dargah Sharif.

Music and dance:

- _____, an eminent indologist in his well known work-'**Feeders of Indian Culture' (1973)** has described in detail the contribution of Islam and Muslims in the reconstruction of Indian Society through the field of **music**.
- Musical creations of Muslims were accepted by Hindus with gratitude and various musical instruments were brought to India by Muslims. Like? **Sitar and Tabla**.
- Ex: **Qawwali** in India.



- Dance was jointly performed by Hindus and Muslim. **Kathak style** (Kathak, The Indo-Persian Dance Style) of muslim countries has held ground in north indian countries for centuries. Kathak is unique in having both Hindu and Muslim gharanas and cultural elements of these gharanas. Kathak performances include Urdu **Ghazals** and commonly used instruments brought during the Mughal period.
- Great contributors: **Amir Khusro**

Architecture:

- Construction of domes, minarets, turrets, arches were from muslims, which was greatly accepted by indians.
- Ex: **Tajmahal, Buland Darwaza, Alai Darwaza.**
- **Khanqahs** (monasteries) provided refuge to the oppressed and wretched, the miserable, the down-trodden and the disinherited, irrespective of caste and creed" (_____).

Gardening:

- **Charbagh style** is a Persian and Indo-Persian quadrilateral garden layout based on the four gardens of Paradise mentioned in the Quran.
- The quadrilateral garden is divided by walkways or flowing water into four smaller parts.

Language:

- The synthesis of Islam and Hinduism gave birth to a new language which has become the common language of both, and that is '**Urdu**'.
- Great contributors:_____

Literary Contribution:

- Islam played a pivotal role in shaping historiography, evident in works like Babar Nama, Akbar Nama, and Ain-i-Akbari, which stand as notable examples of Islamic contributions to historical literature.
- **Frances Pritchett** observes that Persian literary traditions enriched Indian languages.

Paintings:

- Mughal painting is a particular style of South Asian, particularly North Indian (more specifically, modern day India and Pakistan), painting confined to **miniatures** either as **book illustrations** or as **single works** to be kept in albums (muraqqa).
- It emerged from **Persian miniature painting** (itself partly of Chinese origin) and developed in the court of the Mughal Empire of the 16th to 18th centuries. The **Reign of Jahangir** saw painting at its zenith.

Games and entertainment:

- Many Indian sports and entertainments were enriched – Hunting, hawking, kite-flying, and chess (Shatranj) became popular.
- Ex: **Shatranj** (is an old form of chess, as played in the Sasanian Empire. Its origins are in the **Indian game of chaturanga**. **Modern chess** gradually developed from this game, as it was introduced to Europe by contacts in Muslim Al-Andalus (modern Spain) and in Sicily in the 10th century.

Fashion and Jewelry Influence:

- **Mughal dress patterns** were adopted by Hindu rulers, exemplifying the cross-cultural impact of Islamic aesthetics on Indian attire.
- Additionally, the **nose ring (Nath)** evolved into a symbol of Hindu marriage, drawing inspiration from Muslim traditions.

Negatives of the Impact of Islam on Indian Society

- While Islam contributed richly to Indian culture, some aspects also had negative effects. **Romila Thapar** notes that certain rigid practices, like purdah, contributed to the **subordination of women** in Indian society.
- _____ argued that mass conversions sometimes caused social tensions between communities.
- Moreover, the strict enforcement of orthodoxy in certain regimes narrowed religious tolerance at times, in contrast to the syncretic Sufi stream.

The influence of Islam on Indian society was **profound and diverse**. It reshaped art, architecture, language, music, cuisine, education, and social norms, while also introducing new forms of spirituality through Sufism. Though not free from tensions, the **interaction of Islamic and indigenous traditions** produced a rich cultural synthesis that continues to shape Indian identity today.

Impact of Christianity on Indian society:

Christianity entered India as early as 52 AD with the arrival of St. Thomas on the Malabar Coast, but its real spread came with the **European missionaries from the 16th century onwards**. Over time, Christianity shaped **education, healthcare, social reforms, architecture, and culture**, leaving an influence far greater than its numerical strength in India.

"In India, Christianity has been one of the **important factors of modernization and economic development** through the social values it has legitimized".(_____)



Essence of Christianity :

- Universal brotherhood
- Egalitarian outlook
- Service of the under-privileged

Impacts of Christianity:**Christianity's Social Contributions:**

- **Health Initiatives:**
 - Christianity, as a pioneer in social welfare, established hospitals, addressing gaps in government reach. Notably, in North-East India, Christian missions provided healthcare.
 - William Sweet notes how **Christian missions institutionalised hospitals and clinics**, making modern medicine accessible.
 - **CMC Vellore** stands as a legacy of missionary health service.
- **Educational Impact:**
 - **Language Introduction:**
 - The introduction of English as a medium of instruction, influenced by Christian values, became a unifying language among Western-educated individuals.
 - Christianity played a pivotal role in education, establishing schools where government reach was limited.
 - **Eg:** Mizoram's success in achieving a **92% literacy** rate is attributed to Christian missions.
 - **Teotonio R. de Souza** highlights how missionaries introduced **modern education and literacy**, shaping India's early Western-educated elite.
 - _____ (critical but useful to cite) – noted that missionary education had both reformist and cultural assimilationist aims.
- **Social Reforms and Opposition to Caste System:**
 - Christian teachings influenced educated individuals to challenge the Hindu caste system. This opposition led to significant socio-religious reforms.
 - **Example:** Advocacy against caste discrimination by Christian leaders in various regions.
 - **John C. B. Webster** – emphasized missionary efforts in **challenging untouchability** and promoting social justice.
- **Advocacy for Egalitarian Society:**
 - Christianity's emphasis on equality and opposition to social stratification played a crucial role in shaping a more egalitarian society.
- **Cultural Contributions:**
 - Christianity introduced Western architectural elements, musical instruments, and clothing styles.
 - Example: **Basilica of Bom Jesus** in Goa, showcasing Christian architectural influence.
 - Clothing styles: Great influence. Just see what formal boys wear to UPSC interview.
 - Music: Orchestra, guitar, piano etc. got introduced into Indian society during this period.
- **Heritage Rediscovery:**
 - British efforts, often influenced by Christian perspectives, led to the rediscovery of Indian heritage sites like **Sanchi stupas and Ajanta caves**.
 - **Example:** Rediscovery tied to missionary-scholar collaboration.
 - **Henry Taylor (1818)** rediscovered **Sanchi Stupa**.
 - **John Smith (1819)** stumbled upon **Ajanta caves**.
 - **James Prinsep (1837)** deciphered **Brahmi script**.
- **Westernization and Economic Development:**
 - Christianity served as an early channel for Westernization, introducing Western culture and practices that influenced economic development.
 - _____ – Christianity acted as a **channel of Western political ideas**, paving the way for liberalism and democratic institutions.
- **Administrative System Adoption:**
 - Christianity played a role in the unification of India and influenced the adoption of administrative systems, including the three branches of Legislature, Executive, and Judiciary from European models.
 - **Example:** Unification of India's administrative systems under British colonial rule.

Negative Impact of Christianity:**Conversion Conflicts:**

Missionary conversion efforts sometimes led to **communal tensions and conflicts**.

Example: **Kandhamal violence (2008)** in Odisha.

_____ notes that disputes over conversion often created **localised social strife**.



Cultural Assimilation and Loss:

_____ points out that aggressive cultural assimilation sometimes **eroded indigenous practices**, as European customs replaced traditional Indian ways of life.

Despite being only about **2.3 percent of the Indian population**, Christianity's influence on **education, healthcare, social reforms, art, and politics** has been profound. From **Mother Teresa's humanitarian work** to **Mizoram's literacy success**, Christianity has left a legacy of **social change, cultural enrichment, and spiritual inspiration** that continues to shape Indian society today.

5.3.b. "Great" and "Little" tradition

Indian society has always carried both **elite, formal practices** and **local, everyday customs**. Anthropologists use the concepts of **Great and Little Traditions** to study how these two layers of culture coexist and influence each other.

Tradition:

- The word tradition means '**to transmit**'.
- Traditions are **transmitted values and behaviour of any community** which has been persisting over a period of time.
- Traditions are part of culture, and it is observable through oral behaviour, social behaviour and material behaviour.

Redfield categorised traditions into two-

- **Great tradition and**
- **Little tradition.**

Great tradition and Little tradition:

- According to _____, **every society** consists of **two types of traditions**, the tradition of **elite class people**, and the tradition of **non-literate common people**.
- He proposed these concepts in his book _____.
- The **tradition of elite people**, transmitted through **schools, religious centres, written books etc. in a formal way** is called **Great tradition**, and the **tradition of common people** which is **transmitted orally** from **one generation to another** is called **Little tradition**.
- **Great tradition** is **formal, literate and written**, whereas **Little tradition** is **informal, unwritten and oral**.
- As **Great tradition** is **written and formal**, it is spread in a **wide geographical area**, and **Little tradition** is **more or less localised**.
- Though the **Great tradition and Little tradition** are **separate in origin** they are **interdependent and interact with one another**.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN GREAT AND LITTLE TRADITIONS:

Great Tradition	Little Tradition
1. Tradition of elite class people . 2. Emerged from urban centres . 3. Based on religious texts . 4. Transmitted through formal centres and religious text . 5. Spread in a wide area . 6. Organised .	1. Tradition of non-literate peasant/common people . 2. Emerged from the folk community . 3. Mostly based on traditional beliefs . 4. Transmitted orally . 5. More or less localised . 6. Unorganised .

These concepts can be understood from **another angle also**.

- That is, **every society** consists of great and little communities.
- The **tradition of great community** is called **Great tradition** and the **tradition of little community** is called **Little tradition**.
- In **Indian context**, the **Hindu community** is considered as a **great community** and it carries great culture and social structure.
- Within the **boundaries of great communities**, there are **many little communities and their traditions**.
- These communities are found in the **rural and tribal segments of the society**.
- The beliefs and practices associated with the religious texts like **Gita, Ramayana, Upanishads, Bible and Quran** which are transmitted through formal centres are called **Great traditions**.
- The **folklore**, religious practices, magical rituals whose references are not found in the religious epics and which are transmitted orally constitute **Little tradition**.
- The **religious centres** like Gaya, Varanasi etc have great traditions, they have traditional temples where offerings of worship and teachings of Sanskrit is done by sacred specialists.



- These **sacred specialists** also try to popularise the myths and legends, associated with the places and shrines, to peasants.
- Thus **religious attitudes develop in the mind of peasants** and as a result of which several rituals and practices come into being.
- These are performed by Hindu folk on different occasions. **These sacred specialists mediate between great and little traditions and propagate great traditional elements to little tradition.**

Summary

- The terms **Great and Little traditions were coined by an anthropologist named Robert Redfield** in the twentieth century to describe the cultural practices of societies.
- He found that peasants observed **rituals and customs** that emanated from dominant social categories, including **priests and rulers**. These he classified as part of a **Great tradition**.
- At the same time, peasants also followed **local practices** that did not necessarily correspond with those of the great tradition. These he included within the category of **Little tradition**.
- He also noticed that both **Great and Little traditions changed over time, through a process of interaction.**

Prominent Example:

- One of the **most striking examples of this process is evident at Puri, Orissa, where the principal deity was identified, by the twelfth century, as Jagannatha, a form of Vishnu.**
 - **Jagannatha (extreme right) with his sister Subhadra (centre) and his brother Balarama (left)**
 - You will notice that the **deity is represented in a very different way**. In this instance, a local deity, whose image was and continues to be made of wood by local tribal specialists, was recognised as a form of Vishnu.
- At the same time, **Vishnu was visualized in a way that was very different from** that in other parts of the country.
- Such instances of **integration are evident amongst goddess cults** as well. Worship of the goddess, often simply in the form of a stone smeared with ochre, was evidently widespread.
 - These local deities were often incorporated within the **Puranic framework by providing them with an identity as a wife of the principal male deities** – sometimes **they were equated with Lakshmi, the wife of Vishnu, in other instances, with Parvati, the wife of Shiva.**

Limitation:

- While scholars accept the significance of these categories and processes, they are often **uncomfortable with the hierarchy suggested by the terms great and little**. The use of **quotation marks for “great” and “little”** is one way of indicating this.
- _____ has expressed the view that Indian cultural realities are too complex to be understood through a mere **‘bipolar model’** of Great and Little Traditions.
 - His view of traditions is **‘multipolar’**.
 - He has suggested a six fold classification **against the ‘bipolar’ classification**.
 1. **Classical traditions:** Rooted in mythology, Sanskrit texts, and religious lore.
 - Example: *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata* shaping Hindu culture.
 2. **Regional traditions:** Shared cultural traits that give a region its identity, often beyond religion.
 - Example: *Bhangra* in Punjab, *Bihu* in Assam.
 3. **Local traditions:** Restricted to small groups or areas, often tribal or village-based.
 - Example: *Bhuta worship* in Karnataka, *Karam festival* of tribes in Jharkhand.
 4. **Western traditions:** Came through colonial contact, shaped both ideology and lifestyle.
 - Examples: *Railways and telegraph introduced by the British*, *Western dress codes among urban elites*.
 5. **Emergent national traditions:** Linked to revival and national identity formation.
 - Examples: *Ganesh festival popularised by Bal Gangadhar Tilak during the freedom struggle*.
 6. **Sub-cultural traditions:** Practices of specific elite groups.
 - Examples: *Mughal court culture with Persian poetry and etiquette*, *Nawabi traditions of Lucknow such as Kathak and etiquette (tehzeeb)*, *bureaucratic codes and rituals of the Indian Civil Service under the Raj*.
- In view of _____, **the term ‘Great Tradition’ can’t be a static one since there’s constant interaction, and interchange between the two traditions. So, it can’t be described only in terms of books written hundreds and thousands of years ago.**



In conclusion, Redfield's idea of little and great traditions helps us understand the complex nature of Indian society. The **great tradition** represents formal, dominant culture, while the **little tradition** reflects local, everyday practices. Their interaction shows how diversity, cultural mixing, and innovation shape society. Even today, in the age of globalization and modernization, this framework remains a useful tool for studying culture and society.

5.3.b. Universalisation and Parochialisation

McKim Marriott and Milton Singer, the students of **Robert Redfield** who came to India and studied village communities, applied these concepts in Indian context and **formulated various theories like Universalisation and Parochialisation**.

- You have already studied the concepts, Great tradition and Little tradition. You may also have seen local examples of these two traditions.
 - At **Andaloor Kavu** near **Thalassaery** in **Kannur district**, people worship **Daivathar, Angakkaran, and Boppoaran**.
- Theyyams** of these gods are performed during the festival. We can see that this belief which is local and transmitted orally is part of little tradition.
 - But these deities are equated to the great traditional deities such as Sreeraman, Lakshmanan, and Hanuman respectively. Here we cannot place this belief in either of the traditions.
- Why did it happen?**
- It can be due to the **upward and downward movement of traditions**.
- This type of **movement in different traditions was studied by _____**, the student of **Robert Redfield**.
 - While studying about different traditions, **Marriot recognised that great and little traditions** do not remain as separate compartments, but move towards each other.
 - According to **Marriot**, the elements of great tradition move towards little tradition and the elements of little traditions move towards great tradition.
 - He named these movements as **Universalisation and Parochialisation**.
- The upward movement of the elements of little tradition to become a part of great tradition is known as **Universalisation**.
- Parochialisation is the opposite process of Universalisation**.
- It is the **downward movement of the elements of great tradition to merge into little tradition**.

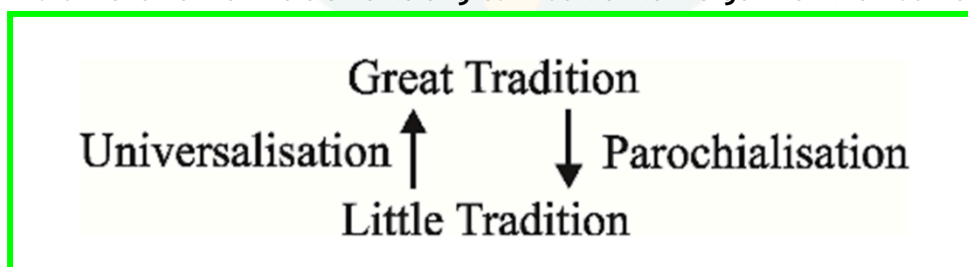


Fig: Universalization and Parochialisation

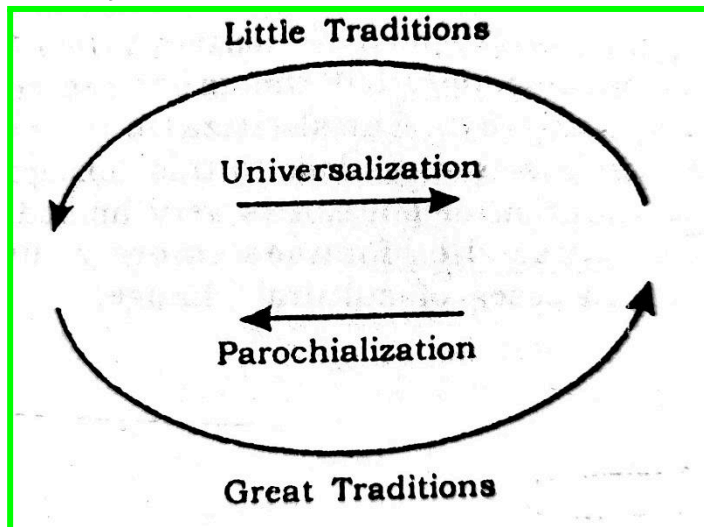
- Parochialisation is the opposite process of Universalisation**. It is the **downward movement of the elements of great tradition to merge into little tradition**.
- Marriot** introduced these two concepts in his book- _____
- Example for Parochialisation:**
 - He cites the example of **Gobardhan pooja** conducted by the people of **Kishangarhi** as an example of parochialisation.
 - Govardhanagiri, a hill located about 40 Kms away from Kishangarhi is worshipped as part of great traditional belief.
 - It was believed that Lord Krishna saved people from the furious Indra by taking Govardhan hill as an umbrella.
 - This belief came down to become the local tradition. People at Kishangarhi worship **heaps of cow dung, imitating the belief of Gobardhan**.
 - Marriot considers this as a **parochialised form of Govardhan puja**. (**Gobardhan, in Hindi means cow dung and Govardhan means the hill Govardhan**) Likewise Marriot suggests the example of adoption of little traditional beliefs by the great tradition.
- Example for universalisation:**
 - For instance, he says, the **Rakhi or Raksha Bandhan is a universalised form of Saluno festival** practiced at Kishangarhi.

- o In Kishangarhi, the married daughters, on the day of Saluno apply tilak of barley on the foreheads of their unmarried sisters and brothers and get money or gifts in return.
- o Likewise, **Brahmin priests tie Rakhi** on their **patrons** (Jajman) and get something in **return**.
- o **Marriot** contends that the **festival of Raksha Bandhan** came into being as a result of **Universalization of festivals like Saluno**.

Limitation:

- **Circular and not two directional:**

- o One of the major drawbacks of this concept is that Universalisation and Parochialisation as a process of explaining cultural change is not two directional but is rather circular and continuous in operation.

**Fig: Universalization and Parochialisation****Example:**

The **Ramayana** started as oral folk stories told in villages, which belonged to the **Little Tradition (LT)**. Later, these tales were shaped into a grand Sanskrit epic by **Valmiki**, making it part of the **Great Tradition (GT)**, the pan-Indian classical heritage studied by elites.

Over time, this GT text was translated into many regional languages. The most famous is **Tulsidas' Ramcharitmanas in Hindi**, which ordinary people treasured as a household scripture. Through recitations in homes and the staging of **Ram Lila** dramas in villages, the epic once again entered the **Little Tradition (LT)**, reshaped and celebrated at the local level. This shows how traditions move in a **circular way**:

- LT (oral folk tales) → GT (Sanskrit Ramayana by Valmiki) → LT again (regional versions, Ram Lila).

Universalisation and **Parochialisation** highlight the constant interaction between **Great Tradition** and **Little Tradition** in India. They show how cultural elements move **upward** into elite traditions and **downward** into local practices, creating a **circular process** of adaptation. Together, they explain the **dynamic** and **continuous nature** of **cultural change** and **integration** in Indian society.

3.3 SACRED COMPLEX

The concept of sacred complex as a focus of anthropological investigation was put forth by **L.P.Vidyarthi (1961)** in his book, _____. Vidyarthi, a follower of the **Chicago School of anthropology**, tried to **analyze the contribution and importance of traditional centers of Indian civilization in a systematic way**. With the study of sacred and traditional Hindu Gaya, the concept of sacred complex came to light in anthropological literature.

Historical Background

- Redfield's concept of "great" tradition and "little" tradition provided an insight to understand Indian civilization. **L.P. Vidyarthi**, a student of _____, undertook studies of Indian villages, using the theoretical framework developed by **Robert Redfield** and **Milton Singer**, American anthropologists of civilizational school.
- Through his **study of the Hindu pilgrim centre Gaya**, located in Magadh, Bihar, **L.P. Vidhyarthi** developed the concept of **Sacred Complex**.

Vidyarthi studied the Sacred and Great Traditional Hindu Gaya and described three analytical concepts in detail:-

- A Sacred geography**
- A set of Sacred Performances**
- A group of Sacred Specialists.**

- **Sacred Geography:** The sacred geography consists of the **place** which is significant in the pilgrim centres because **rites are performed** here. And these geographies help in **cultural transmission of Great Tradition Elements**.
 - For eg: It may be an idol in a temple, a tree, a bathing ghat etc.
- **Sacred Performances:** These are the sets of **rites and rituals** performed by worshippers at different sacred centres, and vary with the nature and importance of each centre. These may be recitation of mantras, floral offerings, etc.
 - For eg: In Gaya – it's Gaya Shraddha.
- **Sacred specialists:** Sacred specialists of a place of pilgrimage maintain a distinct style of life and transmit great traditions to the rural population of India by popularising certain texts, by organising pilgrimage and by officiating as the **ritual and temple priests**.
 - For eg: In Gaya, these are performed by Gayawal Brahmins.

These three concepts conceived **collectively are termed as sacred complexes**.

According to L.P.Vidyarthi, **it is a synthesis of Sacred Geography, Sacred performance and Sacred Specialists**. In his book **Sacred Complex of Hindu Gaya**, L.P. Vidyarthi explains that this place of pilgrimage **reflects a level of combination, continuity, & compromise** between the elements of great tradition and little tradition.

Sacred Complex:

- A sacred complex is an intricate and interdependent grouping of **sacred geographies, sacred performances and sacred specialists**.
- Methodologically, the study of sacred complexes unfolds **channels of cultural transmission** which **helps in the integration of civilisation**.
- It has **played an integrating role by providing a meeting place of different kinds of people and traditions**, of castes and sects, of classes and statuses.
- The mechanism of the sacred complex and the institution of pilgrimage are dependable and effective **means of integration of elements of GT and LT** or the Indian society in general.
- Some extra fodder material
 - [It also cultivates and promotes varieties of creative arts and literature and helps preserve the 'ideal types' (GT elements).
 - It is a reality that binds us together against the geographical diversities and social and linguistic heterogeneity.]

Some additional information:

Other study/visits by LPV:

- Apart from the study of Gaya, Vidyarthi undertook short trips to sacred places like **Benaras (Varanasi), Bhubaneswar, Puri, Deoghar** and paid many visits to many rural temples and bathing centers.

Influenced further study:

Contributions of Scholars to the Study of Sacred Complexes in India:

1. S.C. Saraswati (1962, 1965)

- **Naimisharanya (U.P.):** In the *Institution of Pilgrimage in Nimsar or Ancient Naimisha*, Saraswati examined the network of sacred specialists (priests, pandas), supporting villages, and pilgrimage patterns around this holy centre. He showed how such sacred sites serve as hubs linking surrounding rural populations to larger sacred traditions.
- **Pilgrimage as sacred act:** He argued that pilgrimage itself is a sacred act, and therefore all those who participate acquire a sacred status. This was an important conceptual step, as it treated pilgrimage as a transformative process.
- **Temple organisation in Goa:** Studied the temple system in Goa, highlighting how sacred institutions also regulate **secular life**—for example, community organisation, festivals, and local leadership. This showed that sacred complexes do not just sustain religious life but also shape political, social, and economic activities.
- **Kashi study:** Collaborated with Jha and Vidyarthi on Varanasi. Here, he demonstrated how Kashi embodies **textual and contextual continuity** of sacred geography. Despite changing urban boundaries and descriptions in sacred texts, Kashi remains a vibrant centre of religious integration.

2. Jha (1971, 1977)

- **Janakpur (Nepal, 1971):** In *Sacred Complex of Janakpur*, Jha showed that civilisation transcends political borders. Janakpur is geographically in Nepal, yet deeply tied to the civilisation of Mithila and to Indian religious consciousness. Its sacred narratives (Sita's birthplace) attract pilgrims from India, proving that the boundary of a nation is not the boundary of a civilisation.
- **Janakpur–Ratanpur comparison:** Linked Janakpur with **Ratanpur (Madhya Pradesh)**, illustrating how both towns acted as **religious and secular capitals** of ancient Mithila and Mahakoshala. This shows how sacred complexes could function as nodes of both civilisational and political integration.



- **Jagannath cult of Puri:** In *Rising India* and *Dimensions of Indian Civilisation*, Jha analysed the **origin, development, and rituals of Jagannath worship at Puri**. He studied pilgrims' networks, sacred specialists, and the interplay of local traditions with the pan-Indian cult.
- **Kashi project with Saraswati:** In their joint research, Jha emphasised the **changing boundaries** of Kashi as defined by scriptures and practice. This highlighted that sacred complexes are dynamic phenomena, constantly reinterpreted.

3. S.C. Bharati (1963, 1970)

- Produced a **comprehensive survey** of pilgrimage across traditions.
- Showed how pilgrimage practices cut across **Hindu, Buddhist, and Tantric traditions** while preserving distinctive elements of each.
- His work offered an inter-religious perspective, highlighting the **shared yet contested sacred geographies** of India.
- Stressed the **growth and spread of pilgrimage practices** historically, revealing how new cults and centres emerged alongside older ones.

4. David Sopher (1968)

- Conducted one of the most detailed **field-based studies** of pilgrimage.
- Found that **service castes** (like barbers, washermen, priests) were crucial to sustaining pilgrim activity. In fact, above-average pilgrim activity was strongly linked to the presence of these castes, since they provided necessary services.
- His work showed that pilgrimage centres are not just religious hubs, but also socio-economic systems where caste roles are reinforced and reproduced.
- Concluded that understanding pilgrimage requires attention to caste, economy, and ritual networks together.

5. Bharadwaj (1973)

- Examined pilgrimage within both its **historical and social contexts**.
- Studied **pilgrim fields** (landscapes associated with holy sites), **caste composition of pilgrims**, and the **hierarchical ranking of sacred places**.
- Based on **extensive fieldwork and historical data**, he provided excellent material on how sacred places both mirror and reinforce social hierarchies.
- His work emphasised how sacred complexes function as **living social institutions**, rather than static religious symbols.

6. R.N. Narayan (1974)

- Studied the **Sacred Complex of Deoghar (West Bengal)**.
- Concluded that Deoghar acts as a **microcosm of Indian civilisation**, where pilgrims of many castes, classes, and linguistic backgrounds come together.
- Analysed the **heterogeneity of pilgrims**—covering caste, class, language, educational level, political awareness, and social status.
- His study highlighted that sacred complexes are not homogenous but integrate **diverse and even conflicting groups** into shared rituals and experiences.

7. Patnaik (1977)

- In *Cultural Tradition in Puri*, Patnaik examined the **Jagannath cult**.
- Analysed how **different communities of Puri**—priests, artisans, service castes, pilgrims—are bound together by temple traditions.
- Showed that the Jagannath cult serves as both a **religious and socio-cultural integrator**, linking local society with larger civilisational patterns.

8. Narayana Reddy

- In his study *Sacred Complex of Tirumala: An Anthropological Study*, he applied Vidyarthi's model in detail.
- Analysed all three classical dimensions: **sacred geography (the Tirumala hills)**, **sacred specialists (priests, temple staff)**, and **sacred performances (rituals, festivals, darshan)**.
- Went further by including the **secular dimension**: secular geography, secular specialists, and secular activities (e.g., shops, hotels, secular employment generated by pilgrimage).
- Studied the **socio-economic background of pilgrims** to show how the centre caters to a cross-section of Indian society.
- His work showed how the sacred and secular blend together at pilgrimage centres, proving that sacred complexes are a **holistic cultural system**.

Significance of Sacred Complex:

- The **Sacred Complex** highlights how **Great Tradition** and **Little Tradition** interact, combine, and adapt at pilgrimage centres, showing the continuity of Indian civilisation.
- It serves as a **channel of cultural transmission**, spreading elite religious ideas to local levels, while also allowing folk practices to influence mainstream traditions.



- Pilgrimage centres become spaces of **social integration**, bringing together people of different castes, sects, classes, and regions.
- It also promotes **creative arts, literature, and symbolism**, preserving “ideal types” of cultural and religious life.
- The concept shows that despite **regional, linguistic, and social diversities**, sacred centres act as binding forces for the larger Indian civilisation.

In conclusion, L.P. Vidyarthi's concept of the **Sacred Complex** helps us understand how religion, culture, and society interact in India. By studying elements like myth, ritual, and symbolism, it shows how diverse traditions come together and shape Indian cultural identity. It remains an important tool for anthropologists to study the complexity of religious life in South Asia.

3.3.NATURE-MAN-SPIRIT COMPLEX

The concept of Nature man spirit complex is an attempt **to understand the adaptation of socio-cultural institutions with the local environmental conditions**. It has been observed that there is a constant interaction going on between the social organization, ecological conditions and religious complex in the whole of tribal life.

This concept was first studied by **L.P.Vidyarthi**. **The main principle of this concept is based on cultural ecology, where there would be a constant interaction between Man and Nature. To this, LP Vidyarthi also includes the third element – the spirits.**

Relationship between Nature-man- spirit :

- Nature, Man and spirit interact **out of necessity**. This was the basis of this concept of Nature-Man-Spirit Complex proposed by **Vidyarthi**.
- In it, he describes the culture of a **hill tribe – the Maler** in terms of this complex where the three ingredients of the complex are **interdependent** and **mutually complementary**.
- Nature and Spirit show a great influence on the lives of Tribal people. The statement can be understood through the following example.

Eg: **Maler Tribes** live in the upper side of **Rajmahal hills**. They generally perform **Shifting cultivation (Khallu)** on rajmahal hills and maintain social organisation.

- L.P.Vidyarthi studied man in relation with man. He presented the **four types of Maler spirits** in a framework of sacred geography, sacred performances, and sacred specialists.
 - **Gossaiyan** – the benevolent spirits,
 - **Jiwe Urrkya** – the ancestral spirits,
 - **Alchi** – evil spirits and
 - **Chergani** – spiritual power of a witch or witchcraft,
- However, the spirits they believe in may **broadly** be classified into two :
 1. **Benevolent spirit** who is responsible **for good health, wealth and increased productivity** in agriculture.
 2. **Malevolent spirit** causes **sickness, abortions, ill health and death** etc.
- **Gosaiyyan** will be governing over all the spirits. This Gosaiyyan **serves as a bridge between the Malers and their concept of super human**.
- Maler tribes don't do anything without the approval of Gosaiyyan.
- During some **developmental activities by the government**, Maler tribes were brought down to the Hills. When **they were displaced, some of them became ill. Some died as well**.
- Maler tribes **believed that Malevolent Gosaiyyan was angry** at these tribes and caused ill health and death.

It is based on the fact that arising out of man's close **interaction** with and **dependence** on nature is his belief in the supernatural and the spirit world. It has been found that in tribal India there is an **intimate relationship and interaction between social organizations** on the one hand and **religious complex and ecological conditions** on the other hand.



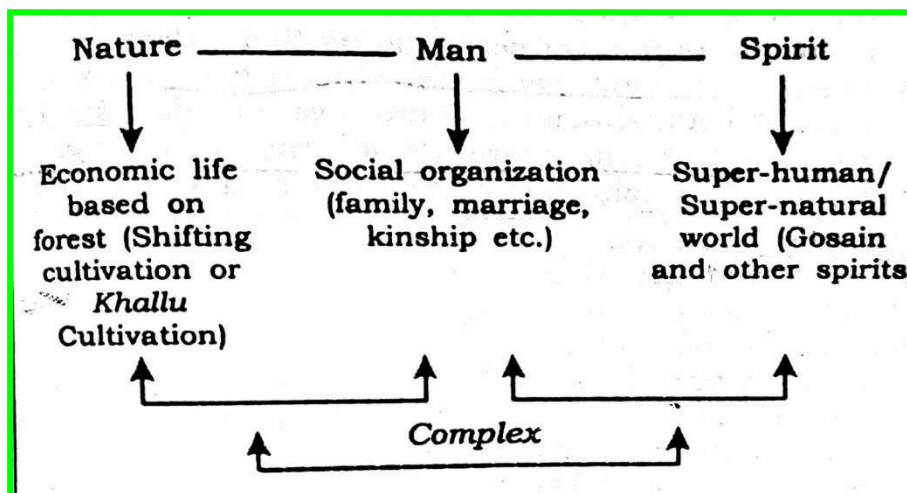


Fig : Nature-man-spirit complex

Thus, the 'nature' and 'spirits' exert profound influence over Maler life and three interrelated factors are in constant interaction with each other

Other such Studies:

- After **Vidyarthi**, many scholars also examined the concept in different ecological settings.
- _____ (1981) studied the Nicobarese of Andaman & Nicobar Islands.
 - In this entirely different setting, a forest island surrounded by sea- Sahay finds similar forces operating.
 - All the fortunes and misfortunes are attributed to benevolent and malevolent spirits, who hover around the hills, forests and sea.
 - Like Maler, blood sacrifice of pig and fowl is essential to propagate the spirit.
 - In short, he says that the Nature-Man-Spirit Complex is the **only model which can best describe the essence of Nicobarese Culture..**
- Similar conclusions were also drawn after the study of:
 - Parahiya of Bihar by _____ (1981).
 - Soliga of Karnataka by _____
 - Onge of Andamans by _____,
 - Pando of M. P. by _____,
 - Kinner of Himachal Pradesh by _____ and
 - Kurmi Of Chotanagpur by _____ (1986) etc..
- _____ (1981) re-examined the concept in his **restudy of Maler**.
 - He studied the same villages that Vidyarthi did two decades ago.
 - He concluded that in spite of many changes in Maler life due to various processes and factors of change, the concept was valid in time dimension as well, and that the complex has not changed.
 - After analysing the various changes in Maler life and the resultant equilibrium, Singh goes on to prove that the Nature-Man-Spirit complex cannot change.
 - It is a constant!
 - Even if the content of the NMS complex may change through time, the complex remains constant.

So, it has been found that in tribal India there is an intimate relationship and interaction between social organizations on the one hand and religious complex and ecological conditions on the other hand.

Significance of the Nature-Man-Spirit (NMS) Complex with Examples

1. Holistic worldview

- The NMS complex highlights the unity of **nature, man, and spirit**, showing that humans are part of the ecological and spiritual order.
- **Example:** Among the **Santhals**, every major ritual (e.g., *Baha festival*) involves worship of village deities along with sacred groves (*Jaherthan*), linking ecology, community, and spirit.

2. Explains resistance to change

- Helps explain why tribes resist relocation, mining, or large-scale dams. Disruption of sacred land disturbs their worldview.
- **Example:** The **Dongria Kondh** tribe of Odisha resisted Vedanta's bauxite mining project in Niyamgiri Hills, seeing it as an attack on their sacred mountain (*Niyam Raja*). Their opposition was rooted in NMS beliefs, not just material livelihood.

Case study:



Niyamgiri hills are home to more than 15,000 **Kondh tribes (Dongria and Kutia)** living in 160 villages spread across the Rayagada and Kalahandi districts of the state. The tribes consider the hills as sacred and worship the hill, calling it '**Niyam Raja**'.



- Till the early 2000s, Dongria Kondhs lived peacefully in quiet and inaccessible hamlets on the slopes of the **Niyamgiri range**, in the Bissam Cuttack, Muniguda and Kalyansingpur blocks of Rayagada district and in the Lanjigarh block of Kalahandi district.
- Trouble began to brew when in 2004 **Vedanta** set up a pit-head alumina refinery at Lanjigarh, a nondescript village on the foothills of Niyamgiri.
- Bauxite is the raw material for alumina and aluminum, and Odisha has 700 million tonnes of known bauxite reserves, of which 88 million tonnes are estimated to be found in Niyamgiri.
- In the rush to acquire mining rights, stringent environmental laws were violated, and the Dongria's consent was not sought.
- Court cases and local opposition did not deter the company. Then, on April 18, 2013, the Supreme Court gave a clear direction that mining clearance can only be given if gram sabhas, comprising Dongrias, agreed to the project.
- In what is perhaps India's first environmental referendum, all 12 villages selected by the government voted against the project.

3. Tool for applied anthropology

- Guides policymakers and anthropologists to frame development projects that are **culturally sensitive**.
- **Example:** Verrier Elwin's recommendations for "**tribal panchsheel**" (1950s) stressed minimal interference and respecting tribal culture, recognising the NMS worldview in development policy.

4. Sustainable use of resources

- Tribes maintain ecological balance through sacred taboos and rituals.
- **Examples:**
 - **Khasi and Garo** tribes of Meghalaya conserve **sacred groves**, where cutting trees or even removing leaves is prohibited.

5. Integration of tradition and development

- NMS complex shows that development must include spiritual and cultural dimensions, not just economic growth.
- **Example:** In Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, tribal communities combine traditional **Sarhul festival** (worship of sal trees and earth goddess) with community-level discussions about agriculture and water use, blending tradition with local development.

In conclusion, the **Nature-Man-Spirit complex** in Indian anthropology shows that development must consider the spiritual and cultural dimensions along with economic and technological ones. It stresses harmony between humans, nature, and the spirit world, making development more holistic and sustainable. This concept is both **theoretically important for Development Anthropology** and **practically relevant for tribal development planners**, whose aim should be to ensure welfare schemes bring not just progress but also **happiness**.

3.2- JAJMANI SYSTEM

The concept of the Jajmani system was first reported by **William H Wiser** in his pioneering work ***The Hindu Jajmani System* (1936)**. He carried out his study in a village called **Karimpur in Uttar Pradesh**. Under this system, each caste group within a village is expected to give certain standardized services to the families of other castes. Here, each person works for a particular family or group of families. Their occupation is based on hereditary ties. This tie-up is continued generation after generation such as father to son, and son to grandson, and so on.

Eg: Yajamani system in TN, Jenmi system of Kerala.

Definition:

Oscar Lewis relied on **Wiser's** study for his 1958 definition of the jajmani system, saying that "**Under this system each caste group within a village is expected to give certain standardized services to the families of other castes.**"

OSCAR LEWIS STUDY ON JAJMANI SYSTEM:

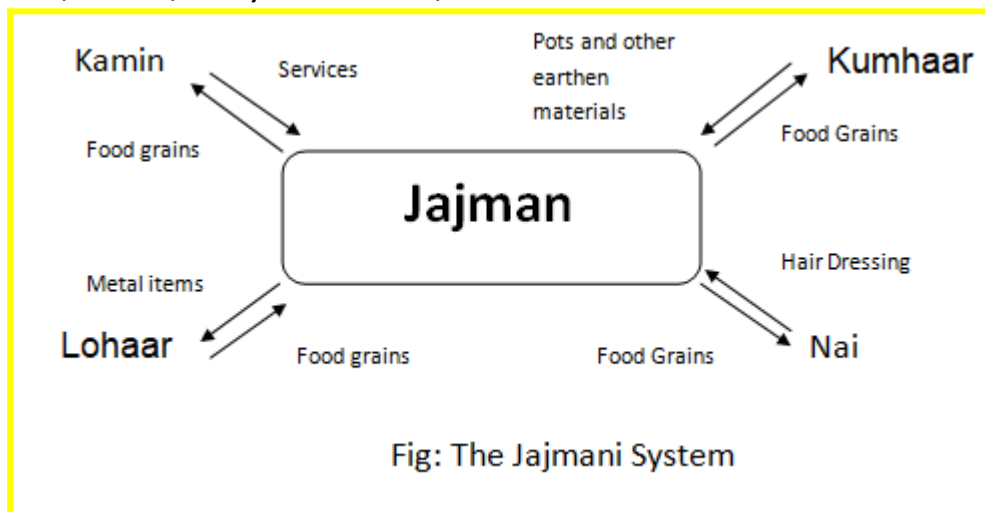


A typical study by **Oscar Lewis** from Rampur village of **Uttar Pradesh** shows the **relationship** between **Jats (land owners)** and other servicing castes like

- Kumhaar (**potter** – supply earthen vessels),
- Lohar (**black smith** – supply agricultural tools),
- Kachhi (**carpenters** – supply wooden tools and their repairing),
- Nai (**barber** – do shaving and cutting of hairs)

How does it work?

- The Jajmani system is essentially an agriculture based system of production and distribution of goods and services.
- Through Jajmani relations, the **servicing castes** like artisans, barbers and washer men **get linked** with the **land-owning dominant castes**.
- Thus, the barber dresses the hair of the villagers; the carpenter meets the woodwork requirements; and the ironsmith makes agricultural implements.
- **The Jajmani system, in short, is a system of social, economic and cultural ties between different caste groups.**



Who are the stakeholders?

- A **Jajman** is a **higher caste person** who receives service from a servicing caste.
- A **Kamin** is a **lower caste person** who **performs his/her service to Jajman** (one who works for somebody – ‘kam karne wala’).
- In the Jajmani system, a **Jajman** earns so much respect that he is often referred to as **Rajah (King)** and Kameen as subjects.
- Though Wisner for the first time drew attention to Jajmani as a tradition and system, he **did not know that the jajmani system is universal in Indian villages**.

Characteristics of Jajmani system:

1. Relationships under Jajmani are permanent:

While a Kamin has no right to leave his Jajman, so also the Jajman has no right to replace his kamin. This ensures life-long fixed and permanent relation between the two and the rural economy remains undisturbed.

2. Jajmani is hereditary:

The jajman-kamin relationship is hereditary in the sense that in case there is separation in the family, these rights are also divided like any other property of the family, according to N.S. Reddy. The rights of Jajmani jobs are passed on to the son, and if anyone has no male heir, Jajmani rights are usually passed on to the son-in-law.

3. Goods against services:

- This system operates without much exchange of money. The relation between Jajman and Kamin is not like an employer and employee.
- The kamin is paid either in cash or in kind. The amount of food grain given to kamin depends upon the nature of services rendered.
- **Oscar Lewis conducted a detailed study of the Jajmani system and documented data on payments made to service castes. For example:**
 - **Carpenter (Khathi):** For repairing agricultural implements made of wood, he received *one mound of foodgrain annually* and about *two to three seers of grain during harvest*.
 - **Sweeper (Chuhra):** For removing filth and preparing dung cakes, he was given *two meals a day*, as much foodgrain as he could carry during harvest, and additional food at the time of marriages.

4. Not only economic but social relationships too:

- The relation between them is not purely economic but **more humanitarian**.

- Accordingly, Jajman takes full responsibility for the welfare of kamin and kamin serves jajman with devotion and dedication.

5. Peace and contentment:

According to **W.H. Wiser**, peace and satisfaction or contentment is a significant feature of the Jajmani system which it provides to the villagers. The kamins of a jajman feel a sense of security. They are not worried about finding employment.

This system provides relief to the jajmans also. They are assured of the services of the kamins.

6. It is also related to Ritual Matters:

- Under the Jajmani system the servicing castes, the kamins perform the ritual and ceremonial duties at the jajman's houses on occasions like birth, marriage and death.
- _____ (1958) has given the example of a **Thakur family (Rajput caste)** in a village in Lucknow district In U.P., which is served by as many as ten castes for the life-cycle rites. All people who help in the function **receive gifts of food, money and clothes** depending partly on custom, partly on jajman's affluence and partly on the recipient's requests.

S. No.	Caste	Role
1	Brahmin	Presides over the ceremony of nama-sanskarana (Giving a name)
2	Sunar (Goldsmith)	Provides gold ornaments for the newborn
3	Dhobi (Washerman)	Washes dirty clothes
4	Nai (Barber)	Carries the messages
5	Khati (carpenter)	Provides wooden stool (patta) on which the child is kept for the ceremony
6	Lohar	Provides kara
7	Kumhar (Potter)	Provides Kulhar (jugs) for keeping drinking water
8	Pasi	Provides patal (leaf plates)
9	Bhangi (scavenger)	Cleans the place after the feast

Disadvantages of the Jajmani system:

- It is an instrument of **exploitation** and discrimination:
 - _____ has pointed out in his study of the Jajmani system in Rampur village, whereas in the past it was based on personal relationship, it has now become an instrument of exploitation of kamins by jajmans.
- It restricts the **social mobility** of lower castes:
 - This system is hereditary, so there is no possibility of changing the occupation. In this way the system has checked social mobility.
- Supported by Caste System:**
 - Caste system is the basis of jajmani system. So this system suffers from all the evils of the caste system. _____ found in his study that the conditions of kamins are miserable and the upper castes subject them to great harassment and trouble.

Different Scholarly perspectives on the Jajmani System:

- _____ (1963): (explains the **occupational division of labour** in an Indian agricultural village)
 - She looks at it as a system of distribution whereby the higher caste land owning families called Jajmans are provided services and products by various lower castes.
- _____ (1953): (Talks about the **social dynamics** of the jajmani system)
 - He says that it is not easy for an agriculturist to remove a family attached to his household and secure the services of another.
- _____ (1972):- (emphasizes upon the **internal functioning** of the Jajmani system)



- a) He says that the Jajmani relations essentially operate at the family level. A Rajput landowning family has its Jajmani ties with one family each from brahmin, barber, carpenter, etc., and a family of service caste offers its services to specific families of Jajmans.

Functions performed by the Jajmani System:

- The Jajmani system is important as it performs important functions and roles both **economically and socially**.
- Its role is to regulate the **division of labour and economic interdependence of castes**.
- It serves to maintain the **Indian village as a self-sufficient unit**.
- It distributes agricultural produce in **exchange for menial and craft services**.
- The system also helps in **maintaining the prestige of higher castes**. The kamin castes are expected to render their services to Jajman castes, for which the kamins are paid in cash or kind at fixed intervals. The clients of kamins may be from the same or different villages.

Factors of change in the Jajmani System:

According to _____, there are **4 major trends** of change in the Jajmani system. They are:

- Rapid transformation of agrarian society from **Subsistence economy to Surplus economy**.
 - The rapid transformation of agrarian society from a subsistence economy to a surplus economy has resulted in changes to the jajmani system as it has led to a shift in economic power from landowners to non-agricultural groups, altering the traditional system of patronage and dependence.
- Rapid transformation followed by the introduction of **modern technology**.
 - The introduction of modern technology has also contributed to changes in the jajmani system by altering traditional occupations and introducing new economic opportunities, leading to changes in the traditional division of labor and patron-client relationships.
- Abolition of intermediaries such as **Zamindars**.
 - The abolition of intermediaries such as zamindars has had a significant impact on the jajmani system by altering the traditional power structure and patron-client relationships between castes, leading to the emergence of new forms of economic and political power.
- Emergence of **associations** and institutions having linkages with urban and national organizations.
 - The emergence of associations and institutions with linkages to urban and national organizations has further contributed to changes in the jajmani system, as it has provided new avenues for social and economic mobility, resulting in the fragmentation of traditional patron-client relationships and the rise of new centers of power and influence.

Decline of Jajmani system:

Its rapid decline was witnessed in the post-independence period. The causes for decline in the Jajmani system are

- Role of State
- Introduction of technological innovations and industrialization
- political mobilization of the dalits and the backward classes

1. Role of state:

The planned development initiated immediately after independence brought about **transformation in the agriculture sector**. Moreover, the state took the initiative in providing various inputs like credit facilities, fertilizers, irrigation, high yielding variety seeds etc.

2. Technical innovation:

With the machine made goods flooding the market and reaching even remote rural areas the rural artisan castes were literally made to compete with the machines.

Some changes include:

- With the growing availability and consequent increased use of **safety razors**, the practice of **self shaving** became popular, minimizing **the role of village barbers**.
- With the advent of **steel utensils**, the importance of **potters declined**
- With the advent of **bore wells and hand pumps**, the dependence on **kahaars** (drawers and carriers of water declined)

3. Political mobilization of backward classes and backward castes:

With the promulgation of the constitution, the State became committed to **upliftment and empowerment** of backward classes. One of the profound changes in contemporary Indian society has been the emergence of a **new sense of identity** among the dalits and the other backward classes.

The democratic assertion of the backward segments of Indian population and their political mobilization in different parts of the country was a serious blow to the exploitative Jajmani system based on the monopolistic rights of the landed higher castes controlling the means of production in the traditional agrarian economy. With the new found **confidence and democratic assertion by the backward classes** the Jajmani system has suffered a serious setback.



3.2- TRIBE-CASTE CONTINUUM

- **Historical background:** The concept of 'continuum' was initially coined by _____ . Here he adopted the 'Folk-urban' continuum model.
 - 'The Folk-Urban Continuum' posits that the cultural shift from rural to urban is a gradual process, illustrating a spectrum of changes in lifestyle, values, and socio-economic structures, reflecting nuanced transitions between close-knit, tradition-bound folk societies and diverse, adaptive urban societies.
 - In simple terms, a continuum refers to a gradual progression or range of something without any clear boundaries or sudden changes.
- Influenced by this model, other scholars borrowed this conceptual framework and rechristened it as the 'Tribe-Caste Continuum'.
- When scholars like **Bailey and Surajith Sinha** studied the social situation in India, they realized that the **Tribe-Caste continuum** is the process of **social mobility** taking place among Indian villages and tribal communities.

Attempts made by scholars to distinguish between Tribe and Caste:

- _____'s classification:
 - His distinction is more in terms of **religious beliefs and practices**;
 - he classified the **group into a tribe** if it has **animist beliefs**
 - or else **groups were classified into caste**.
 - The **economic, political and ecological factors were of secondary importance**.
- _____ Classification:

He made distinctions between the tribe and caste based on

 1. **Relative Geographic Isolation:**
The tribes are **geographically isolated, being concentrated in areas which are or have been more or less inaccessible**. A tribe is a world within itself having few external social ties, whereas a **caste is by its nature, is a part of a larger whole**, being linked by multifarious ties with other castes.
 2. **Dialect they speak:**
The tribes speak a **variety of dialects** which can be shown to **differ** on a number of important counts from **major Indian languages**.
 3. **Religion:**
Religion, unlike language, is a loose criterion, for what we encounter is **continuum without sharp breaks** and where we draw the line between 'tribal' and 'non-tribal' remains arbitrary.
- **FG Bailey :**
 - **Bailey took all the points, raised** by various sociologists and social anthropologists, into account and presented a scheme to **discriminate between tribe and caste in structural terms**.
 - He suggests that we should curb the tendency to view 'tribe' and 'caste' disjunctively. Instead, **they should be viewed in terms of continuum**.
 - Bailey further argued that a **caste society is organic and hierarchical** while a **tribal society is 'segmentary and egalitarian'**.
 - Thus, he seeks to make the **distinction not in terms of the totality of behaviour** but, in a more limited way, in **relation to the politico-economic system**.
 - **Bailey is also aware of the change occurring in Indian society**. He clearly sees that both **caste and tribe are getting transformed**.
 - He declares that **"both caste and tribe are being merged into a different system which is neither one nor the other"**.
 - **Limitation:**
 - In such a social scenario where caste and tribe are ceasing to be such, according to their classical points of distinction, the practical value of even Bailey's scheme is limited.
- **Surajit Sinha:**
 - Surajith Sinha, a disciple of Redfield, tried to understand the **tribe-caste continuum on the basis of his fieldwork among the tribes of Bastar**.
 - He opines that the lower castes in India seem to share with tribes the **emphasis of equality** in social behaviour within their ethnic group, by giving considerable **freedom for women in cultural activities**.
 - Even the **supernatural beliefs of these lower castes have some similarities with that of tribes**.
- **Tribes and Hinduisation:**
 - **Ghurye (1943)** calls the tribal populations of India as an imperfectly integrated segment of the Hindus - '**backward hindus**'.
 - The presence of **references of tribes like Khasa and Bhils** in the epics and **texts of the Great traditions** such as Ramayana, Mahabharata, etc. show that despite their general isolation, the tribes did maintain some cultural contacts with Hindu society.
 - **Bhils of Central India and Parvati's curse:**



- The Bhils of Central India, traditionally hunter-gatherers and pastoralists, explain their lack of farming through a myth.
- According to the story, Parvati requested Lord Shiva to gift her brothers (the Bhils) something valuable. Shiva gave them his sacred bull, Nandi, which could have been used for ploughing their barren lands. But the brothers, driven by greed, killed Nandi hoping to find treasure inside.
- Enraged, Parvati cursed them and their descendants that they would never be able to farm. Hence, the Bhils remained outside the farming tradition.
- This myth not only explains their non-agrarian way of life but also links the Bhils to Hindu deities like Shiva and Parvati, showing how tribal identity and belief systems were absorbed into the broader Hindu framework.
- Such stories also pass on an important lesson of respect towards the natural world to the younger generation.
- _____ in his '**Hindu Methods of Tribal Absorption**' 1941, showed the amount of Jati influence on the tribes of **Odisha**.
 - He explained how Hindu society gradually absorbed tribal groups into its fold. Some tribes became fully integrated into the broader social, economic, political, and religious framework, while others were incorporated only partially, to varying degrees.
- Similarly, _____ in '**The Santhal: A Tribe in Search of a Great Tradition**' 1965, shows how a number of tribes are now being attracted towards Hinduism due to influences of Hindu societies. In certain cases, due to the process of Hinduisation of tribes, many tribes remain 'tribes' for namesake only.

Examples of Interaction between Tribes and Hindu Society:

1. Jenu-Kuruba (Karnataka)

- A food-gathering tribe skilled in catching and training elephants.
- Supplied elephants to temples and state armies.
- Also supplied forest products in exchange for goods of necessity.
- Paid taxes and rents, showing economic integration with regional systems.

2. Toda (Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu)

- Though primarily pastoral, they worshipped the deity at **Nanjangud (Karnataka)**, about 140 km away across dense forests.
- Shows long-distance religious interaction.
- Those practising settled cultivation developed contacts with neighbouring peasants and caste groups.

3. Munda (Jharkhand, 19th century)

- Socially and economically integrated with neighbouring populations.
- Participated in local markets and shared agricultural practices.

Mythological Narratives as Interaction:

a) Guru Dronacharya and Ekalavya

- Ekalavya, a tribal boy, tried to learn archery from Guru Drona.
- Denied training due to his background, he practised on his own and became highly skilled.
- Drona, to maintain Arjuna's supremacy, demanded Ekalavya's thumb as *guru-dakshina*.
- Reflects the unequal interaction of tribes with caste society.

b) Bhima and Hidimbi

- After the *Lakshagriha* (house of lac) incident, the Pandavas lived in a forest.
- Bhima encountered **Hidimba**, a tribal woman, who fell in love with him.
- After Bhima killed her brother Hidimb, Bhima married Hidimba with Kunti's consent.
- Their son **Ghatotkacha** later played a vital role in the Mahabharata war.
- Shows integration of a tribal lineage into the epic Hindu tradition.

In conclusion, the **tribe-caste continuum** is a **complex** and **dynamic concept** that has been studied and analyzed by various **anthropologists** over time. While there are differences in how **scholars** have **classified** and **understood** this continuum, it remains a **useful tool** for understanding **social mobility** and **diversity** in **Indian society**. However, with the **changing times** and increasing influences of **Hinduism** and other factors, the traditional **distinctions** between **tribe** and **caste** are becoming less clear.



5.3 (a) SANSKRITIZATION, WESTERNIZATION AND MODERNIZATION

SANSKRITIZATION:

Unlike the book view, which says that the caste system is rigid, there was always **inter-caste mobility**. To explain this process of social mobility, _____ came up with the concept of Sanskritization and Westernization. He made the first systematic attempt in his significant and path breaking study, _____ (1952) to define, analyze and understand the process of social change in Indian society.

M. N Srinivas says that the caste system in India has never been so rigid that individuals or castes cannot alter or raise their status. He defines Sanskritization as the **"Process by which a low caste or tribe or other group takes over the customs, rituals, beliefs, ideology and lifestyle of a higher caste and in particular 'twice born' (dwija) caste"**.

Changes adopted:

Aspiring lower castes or any group may give up non-vegetarianism, consumption of liquor, animal sacrifice etc and imitate the Brahmins lifestyle in matters of food, dress and rituals. Other than these we have a list of changes adopted by an aspiring lower caste as part of this Cultural Emulation, which led to Cultural erosion.

Role of Dominant Castes in Sanskritisation:

Srinivas notes that the mediation of Sanskritisation models is influenced by local dominant castes. Brahmin-dominated areas transmit a Brahminical model, while Rajput or Bania-dominated regions emphasize Kshatriya or Vaisya models.

Examples from different regions

a. **Bihar:** Scheduled castes like Rajwars claim Kshatriya status, while backward castes like Koyaris identify as Kushwaha Kshatriya. Dusadh, another scheduled caste, adopts the identity of Gahlout Kshatriya.

b. **Maharashtra and Rajasthan:** Mahar and Pasi castes abandon polluting occupations, striving to upgrade their social position.

Impact of the Culture Emulation:

- The **autonomy of the women** and the freedom to choose their life partner is lost.
- The family structure began to change to **orthodox Hindu Joint family** with the strong **authority of father, and monogamy**.
- The **food habits** also began to change. Eating beef and pork, consumption of liquor were abandoned. The system of dowry replaced bride price.
- Donning of **sacred thread**, giving up the sacrifice of pigs at the time of wedding were also because of this cultural emulation.

Hostility faced by lower castes during Sanskritization:

It was not always easy for the lower castes to move up the social hierarchy by emulating the upper castes. They may have to face hostility from the castes of middle strata, when they try to start using shoes or wear neat and clean clothes.

Example: In Travancore, lower caste women (like Nadars and Ezhavas) had to pay a *mulakkaram* or "breast tax" if they wished to cover their upper body. The **fictional story of Nangeli** depicts an Ezhava woman in early 19th-century Cherthala (Travancore) who supposedly cut off her breasts in protest against this humiliating tax. According to the legend, she presented them to the tax collector on a plantain leaf and died of blood loss. This shows the extreme hostility and resistance lower castes faced when they tried to emulate upper-caste practices of dress and dignity.

- **{EXTRA INFORMATION JUST FOR YOUR KNOWLEDGE:** Similarly for **men**, this poll tax was called **talakkaram** (literally "head tax") or sometimes **meeshakkaram** ("moustache tax"). It basically meant that once a man was considered mature (signaled by growing a moustache), he had to start paying this tax to the state. So, in simple terms, it was simply the **compulsory head tax men of lower castes** had to pay when they became adults.}

Negative Effects of Sanskritisation:

Ironically, despite their low social status, **many lower castes are found more liberal, permissive and progressive**. Their liberal and positive attitude especially towards the position of women, sexual conduct, freedom to choose life partners etc. are worth emulating but they **tend to become conservative and adopt retrograde measures in order to become 'Sanskritized'**.

Eg: Adoption of dowry, early marriage, etc.

Sanskritization – A clamour for Higher status or for Low status?

An interesting contradiction is seen here:

- **"Lower" castes which have become prosperous or powerful or educated** like to assert their claim to a **higher place in the hierarchy by resorting to sanskritization**.
- On the other hand they struggle **fiercely to retain their "backward" status** for taking advantage of educational concessions and government jobs. Modern India is full of contradictions.



New agents of Sanskritization:

Srinivas talks of the festivals of the village deities and calendrical festivals being increasingly Sanskritized. The religious figures enjoy the audience which they couldn't have dreamt of before the **newspapers, the microphone and the radio/televisions** are acting as new agents of Sanskritization.

Sanskritization among Non-Hindu Communities:

- **Cultural Emulation** for the sake of **status elevation** has been the **prime motive force** among the non-Hindu communities too.
- **A mode of tribal Absorption into Hindu fold:**
 - Talking of the **cohesive role of Sanskritization** especially in the **case of a group external to Hinduism** such as a **tribe**, Sanskritization resulted in **drawing it into the Hindu fold**, which necessarily involved its becoming a caste having regular relations with other local castes.
 - When we talk of **tribal absorption into the Hindu fold**, the **examples of Meena from Rajasthan, Santhal and Munda from Bihar and West Bengal, Jounsari, Khasas and Tharu from Uttar Pradesh** and similar others immediately come to mind.
 - **Central India:** Tribal groups like Gonds, Cheros, Sudha Saoras, and Paudi Bhuiyans undergo Sanskritisation. Sudha Sauras and Paudi Bhuiyans in Odisha adopt Brahminical practices, abandoning earlier customs.

Other motives in Sanskritization:

We must not forget that in several cases the **motive force is not always cultural imitation per se but an expression of challenge and revolt against socio-economic deprivation and frustration** like in the case of a **lower caste insisting to carry its bride in a palanquin or the bridegroom riding a horse**.

And here comes the most significant question: **why do the sanskritization of lower castes imitate or emulate the lifestyle and cultural elements of their traditional 'exploiters' and 'oppressors'? Why does a human group imitate a group hated by it?**

One of the plausible explanations as given by **Harold Gould (1988)** tells us that the "**Prime motive force** behind Sanskritization is the factor of **repressed hostility** which manifests itself **not in the form of rejecting the caste system but in the form of its victims trying to seize control of it** and thereby expiate their frustrations on the same battlefield where they acquired them. Only then, can there be a sense of satisfaction in something achieved that is **tangible, concrete, and relevant to past experience**."

In other words, it may not be to be seen as higher status, but to show that they're capable of such practices of the earlier 'oppressors' (upper castes).

Variants of the Process:**a. Resanskritisation**

- **Meaning:** This refers to cases where a caste or community temporarily moves away from Sanskritic practices due to external social, political, or economic influences, but later returns to them.
- **Explanation:** Sometimes groups adopt reformist, modernist, or even Western practices, abandoning rituals, vegetarianism, or caste-based customs. Later, in response to social pressures, revivalist movements, or the desire to reaffirm identity, they re-adopt the very Brahmanical practices they had discarded.
- **Examples:**
 - The **Lingayats in Karnataka:** Originally a radical bhakti movement led by Basavanna in the 12th century that rejected Brahminical orthodoxy, ritualism, and caste hierarchy. Over time, however, sections of Lingayats began incorporating many Hindu-Sanskritic practices (idol worship, temple rituals) into their religious life. This is often cited as an example of *resanskritisation*.
 - The **Arya Samaj followers:** In some regions, reformist Hindus rejected idol worship and rituals, but later generations reintroduced many Sanskritic practices as part of mainstream Hindu identity.

b. Desanskritisation

- **Meaning:** This is the opposite trend, where groups that had adopted Sanskritic practices deliberately abandon them to revive their indigenous traditions.
- **Explanation:** It reflects disillusionment with Sanskritisation, especially when it fails to deliver real social mobility, or when communities feel their original culture and autonomy are eroded. It often arises in contexts of tribal assertion and identity movements.
- **Examples:**
 - The **Ramnamis of Chhattisgarh:** A Dalit sect who adopted Vaishnav bhakti practices, but rejected Brahminical dominance by tattooing "Ram" on their bodies and refusing to follow orthodox rituals. Their movement is seen as desanskritisation because it consciously broke away from priestly mediation.
 - The **Jharkhand tribal movements (Santhal, Munda, Ho, Oraon):** During colonial and post-colonial times, these tribes resisted absorption into the Hindu fold. Movements like **Sarna revivalism** in Jharkhand emphasise worship of nature spirits and ancestral rituals, rejecting Hindu deities and temples.
 - The **Adi Dharma Movement among Dalits in Bengal:** Some Dalit groups rejected Brahmanical Hinduism and reclaimed distinct cultural practices, identifying themselves as outside Hinduism.



Scholar Views on Sanskritisation:**Milton Singer**

- Drew attention to the fact that there are multiple models of Sanskritisation, not just Brahminical. Suggested that Brahmins, Kshatriyas, and Vaishyas could all be models depending on locality and context.
- Pointed out variations even among Brahmins and Kshatriyas, making the imitation model context-specific.
- Later (1968) argued that contemporary mobility is less about Sanskritisation and more about **political participation**. Emphasised that groups increasingly prefer power acquisition over ritual imitation.

Yogendra Singh

- Extended Sanskritisation beyond castes to the *varna* framework.
- Critiqued it as being too focused on hierarchy.
- Suggested that Sanskritisation may manifest **repressed inter-class hostility**, where lower castes do not reject the system but try to seize control of it.
- Also argued that in some contexts, Sanskritisation can be seen as a **protest against the normative structure** of Hinduism (e.g., rejection of karma theory, rituals, or Brahminical dominance).

William Rowe

- Supported the view that Sanskritisation is less functional today compared to political participation as a means of mobility.

Sanskritization highlights how **cultural emulation** has historically been a path of aspiration for many **lower castes** and **tribes**, yet its gains have largely been **symbolic rather than structural**. While it explains important dimensions of **social mobility**, it also reinforces **Brahmanical values** and **caste hierarchy**. In contemporary India, processes like **desanskritisation**, along with **modern education, politics, and law**, increasingly provide alternative routes for **dignity and equality** beyond Sanskritic models.

Westernisation

M. N. Srinivas used the term **Westernisation** to describe the changes in Indian society and culture brought about by more than 150 years of British rule. It refers to all **cultural changes** and **institutional innovations** in India that came into being due to contact with Western nations, particularly Britain.

On a wider plane, Westernisation includes a **scientific approach**, emphasis on **materialism** (rather than spiritualism), **individualism**, a **liberal approach** toward social problems, **humanism, equality, egalitarianism, and rationalism**. The **establishment of modern institutions** like universities, railways, courts, legislatures, and technological and educational centers, as well as the rise of **nationalism** and new political culture, are all by-products of Westernisation.

Impacts of Westernisation in India

Westernisation brought deep institutional and cultural shifts:

- **Scientific and Educational Growth:** Establishment of modern schools, colleges, universities, and scientific institutions.
- **Political Change:** Rise of nationalism, modern leadership, democratic institutions, and a new political culture.
- **Caste and Family Transformation:** Lessening of caste rigidity, disintegration of joint families, and new forms of social reform movements.
- **Economic Change:** Decline of cottage industries, promotion of commercial crops, and new land management systems.
- **Social Values:** Spread of ideals like democracy, equality, social justice, and a uniform administrative system across the country.

To be precise, humanitarianism and rationalism—key elements of Westernisation—led to **social reform movements** such as abolition of sati, widow remarriage, and rise of social reformers like Raja Ram Mohan Roy.

Westernisation and Sanskritisation

M. N. Srinivas explained that **Westernisation and Sanskritisation** are closely linked.

- **Westernisation accelerates Sanskritisation:** new communication and transport (railways, post, newspapers) increased **pilgrimages, caste meetings, and religious propaganda**. Today, one can **book a Tirupati pooja online** or visit multiple holy sites easily, which indirectly strengthens Sanskritisation.
- **Westernisation weakens Sanskritisation:** the highly Westernised live more in the **world of class rather than caste**. They may ignore **ritual pollution rules**, eat non-vegetarian food, drop caste names, intermarry, or give up the **sacred thread**. They adopt Western models over Sanskritic traditions.
- **Higher castes turning to Westernisation:** Many Brahmins and Rajputs shifted to Western education and migration as a way to maintain social distance. **Harold Gould** observed that once a caste is fully Sanskritised, it cannot rise further. If equality is accepted, caste hierarchy collapses. So, higher castes used **Western lifestyles** as an alternative form of distinction.



Three Views on Westernisation

1. Conflict View:

- a. _____ argued that Westernisation brings **cultural conflicts between the West and the Rest**. He suggested three responses for non-Western societies:
 - i. **Isolation** to preserve their values.
 - ii. **Band-wagoning** (openly joining) the West and accepting its values and institutions.
 - iii. **Balancing** Western power by modernization while retaining their own cultural identity.

2. Optimistic View:

- a. _____ took a more **optimistic view**. He believed a new **global civilization** is emerging where non-Western nations admire and follow Western living standards, but the world must adopt **shared policies** to ensure balance of global and national interests. However, in *The New Asian Hemisphere*, he observed that **Western influence is unraveling** as Eastern powers like China rise. He noted the **loss of Western credibility**, double standards, and increasing **anti-American sentiment**, showing that the dominance of the West is being challenged.

3. Critical View:

- a. **Edward Said** (*Orientalism*) explained Westernisation as part of **colonial domination**. By essentializing subject populations, the West reinforced its own superiority and justified rule. For example, leaders like **Balfour** argued that Egyptians needed British guidance. Said showed how **knowledge and domination** were intertwined in colonial contexts.

Indian Context

_____ in his work on early Congress politics showed that the **Indian nationalist movement** drew heavily from Western ideas of **democracy and rights**. The ruling class after independence also retained Westernized habits. For example, **Jawaharlal Nehru**, as _____ observes, carried such Britishness that he once called himself "the last Englishman to rule India."

This shows that while Westernisation disrupted traditional structures, it also gave India the ideological foundation for **nationalism, democracy, and social reform**.

Limitations

1. Over-generalised concept

- Clubs together very different influences (English education, railways, parliamentary democracy, Western dress) under one label without differentiating their effects.

2. Eurocentric bias

- Assumes Western values (rationalism, secularism, liberalism) as inherently progressive, ignoring indigenous reforms and non-Western sources of change.

3. Neglects selective adoption

- Communities did not adopt Westernisation uniformly. For example, modern science was accepted, but Christianisation resisted. The theory glosses over this selective process.

4. Ignores resistance

- Many groups opposed Western influence (e.g., Swadeshi movement, revivalist reform movements), which the concept does not account for adequately.

5. Static view of the West

- Treats "the West" as a fixed model, ignoring internal contradictions and evolving nature of Western societies themselves.

Westernisation in India had **both positive and negative effects**. It promoted **nationalism, democracy, and social reforms**, but also **disrupted traditional industries and cultures**. Its link with Sanskritisation is complex—sometimes strengthening caste identity, sometimes eroding it by creating class-based identities. Globally, views differ: **Huntington warns of cultural conflict, Mahbubani sees convergence, McLane highlights Western influence on Indian nationalism, and Nanda shows how deeply Westernisation shaped Nehru and India's elite**. Together, these views show Westernisation as a force of change that India both adopted and resisted.

Modernization

Modernization has been one of the central themes in sociology and anthropology, particularly after World War II, when newly independent nations of Asia, Africa, and Latin America sought models for development. It refers to the shift from traditional, agrarian, and hierarchical societies toward modern, industrial, secular, and democratic ones.

- _____: From a historical viewpoint modernization is the process of change towards those types of social, economic, and political systems which were developed in Western Europe and North America from the seventeenth to nineteenth centuries, and later spread to South America, Asia, and Africa during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.
- _____: Modernization symbolizes a **rational attitude** towards issues and their evaluation, not from a **particularistic point of view**.



Modernization rests on the **idea of progress** – that scientific, technological, and institutional advancement leads to an improvement in the human condition. It also implies the **decline of feudal structures, superstition, and rigid dogmatism**.

I) Key Features of Modernization:

- Based on **progress**, emphasizing advancements in science, technology, and social organization.
- Signifies a **decline in feudalism, superstition, and rigid dogmatism**.
- Promotes **rationality, equality, democracy, and secularism**.

II) Historical Roots of Modernization:

1. Neolithic Revolution (c. 10,000 BCE)

- **Technological Change:** Development of ploughs and refined stone tools raised land productivity dramatically.
- **Settlements:** Nomadic bands settled into permanent villages.
- **Economic Organization:** Surplus production enabled specialization into artisans, merchants, priests, and administrators.
- **Significance:** Marked the first great leap toward organized societies and proto-civilizations.

2. Industrial Revolution (18th–19th Century)

- **Technological Innovations:** Steam engine, electricity, telegraph, internal combustion engine, and factory system.
- **Agricultural Modernization:** Denmark and New Zealand industrialized through mechanization of agriculture, transforming farms into “rural factories.”
- **Social Impact:** Industrialization dismantled rigid agrarian hierarchies, creating new classes and urban cultures.
- **Political Revolutions:** The American and French revolutions introduced democracy and self-determination as modern political ideals.

3. Cultural Dimension

- In _____ argued that Protestantism encouraged rational discipline and work ethic.
- This “this-worldly orientation” was well-suited for industrial capitalism, unlike Catholicism and Eastern religions which were more otherworldly.

III) Modernization vs Westernization:

_____ (1988): Modernization is less value-loaded than Westernization. While Westernization implies borrowing Western practices, modernization emphasizes rational and scientific progress without threatening cultural identity.

- **Westernisation = Modernisation:**
 - Railways, telegraphs, postal services, and English education introduced by the British modernised communication and literacy.
 - Constitutional democracy in India, though Western in origin, modernised political structures.
- **Westernisation ≠ Modernisation:**
 - Blind imitation of Western fashion, fast food, or Valentine’s Day does not structurally modernise society.
 - Example: Wearing suits in Indian summers may symbolize Western influence but lacks rationality in local context.
- **Modernisation Beyond the West:**
 - Borrowing from **other societies:** Green Revolution in India drew from Mexico and Philippines.
 - **Indigenous reform:** Arya Samaj, Brahmo Samaj, and Gandhi’s Khadi and Panchayati Raj show modernization from within.

Takeaway: Westernisation may sometimes lead to modernization, but modernization is broader and can come from Western, non-Western, or indigenous sources.

IV) Features of a Modernized Personality (_____)

1. Empathy

- Ability to see from another’s perspective.
- Example: **B.R. Ambedkar’s temple entry and anti-untouchability struggles** reflected empathy for Dalits, demanding dignity and equality.
- Example: In Saudi Arabia, relaxation of rigid dress codes and curbing of religious police showed empathy for changing aspirations of citizens.

2. Mobility

- Refers to both geographical and social mobility.
- Example: Ambedkar’s rise from untouchable origins to the chief framer of the Constitution illustrates upward mobility.
- Example: The lifting of the driving ban for Saudi women expanded both physical and social mobility.

3. High Participation

- Greater involvement in political, economic, and social life.
- Example: Dalits mobilising through Ambedkar’s leadership in protests and politics.
- Example: Saudi women joining the workforce, politics, and sports under Vision 2030.



V) Indian Model of Modernization:

- _____ (1974): "There is no standard model of modernization and no fixed path for its attainment. Developing societies can adopt a model of their choice."
- India's chosen path rests on **democracy, secularism, and social justice**.
- Adoption of modern science and technology is central.
- Example: Directive Principle Article 48 calls for modernising agriculture and animal husbandry.
- But challenges remain: **regional imbalances, corruption, nepotism, and uneven diffusion of benefits**.

VI) Contemporary Issues in Modernization:

- **Superstition vs Rationality:** NCRB data (2021) showed 74 deaths from witchcraft and human sacrifice, revealing gaps in modernization. Activists like Narendra Dabholkar campaigned for a national anti-superstition law.
- **Women's Rights:** Demands for entry into mosques and equal inheritance laws show that modernization is still contested.
- **Religious Conservatism:** Movements resisting reforms often brand women activists or minorities as "Westernized" or "anti-religion."

VII) Limitations of the Concept/Theory of Modernization

1. **Not a uniform or linear process**
 - Modernization does not move steadily forward. India shows parallel realities – IT hubs like Bengaluru coexisting with witchcraft-related deaths (NCRB 2021).
 - Indigenous reform (Arya Samaj, Khadi, Panchayati Raj) often overlaps with Western borrowings (railways, parliament), showing multiple and uneven tracks.
2. **Neglect of inequality and exclusion**
 - Modernization often benefits elites more than marginal groups.
 - Example: Green Revolution raised productivity but widened regional and class divides, leaving tribal farmers and rainfed areas behind.
3. **Resistance from cultural and religious conservatism**
 - Modern reforms are often branded as "Western" or "anti-tradition".
 - Example: women's demands for mosque entry or equal inheritance in Muslim communities face pushback despite being about equality.
4. **Overemphasis on progress, underestimation of costs**
 - Modernization theory assumes scientific and industrial progress automatically improves life.
 - In reality, it brings environmental degradation (industrial pollution, climate crisis) and new social stresses (urban alienation, consumerism).
5. **Alternative modernities sometimes overlooked**
 - Models like Gandhian decentralisation or indigenous tribal visions of sustainable living get sidelined because mainstream modernization theory privileges industry and urbanisation.
 - Example: Gandhi's Panchayati Raj vision was dismissed as "backward" during Nehru's focus on heavy industry, though today it is seen as relevant for sustainable development.

Thus, Modernization is not a uniform or linear process. It is multidimensional, encompassing economic, political, and social transformation. In India, modernization has been shaped by **Western models, non-Western emulation, and indigenous reforms**.

As **Yogendra Singh** emphasizes, modernization represents a rational and universal outlook. **S.C. Dube** reminds us that modernization need not erase cultural roots but can coexist with them.

At its core, modernization is about **progress, dignity, and inclusivity**. Whether through Ambedkar's social reforms, Gandhi's indigenous models, Muslim women's struggles for equality, or tribal representation in politics, modernization remains a continuous journey toward a more just and rational society.

Paper 2– Chapter – 5.2

RELIGIOUS AND LINGUISTIC MINORITIES**Table: Religious Communities of India, 2011**

Religious Group	Population (in million)	% of Total
Hindus	966.3	79.8



Muslims	172.2	14.2
Christians	27.8	2.3
Sikhs	20.8	1.7
Buddhists	8.4	0.7
Jains	4.5	0.4
Other Religions and Persuasions (ORP)	7.9	0.7
Religion Not Stated	2.9	0.2

Source: Census of India, 2011

The expression "**Minorities**" has been employed at only **four places** in the Indian constitution. The headnote of **Article 29** uses the term Minorities, Then the expression "minority or minorities" is employed in the headnote of **Article 30** and in **Clause (1) and Clause (2) of Article 30**. Interestingly **no definition** of the term is given by the constitution.

Who are Minorities?

- The Constitution of India uses the word 'Minority' or its plural form in some **articles- 29 to 30 and 350A to 350B** but does not define it anymore.
- **Article 29** has the word "minorities" in its marginal heading but speaks of "any sections of citizens having a **distinct language, script or culture**". This may be a whole community generally seen as a minority or a group within a majority community.
 - It talks about protection of the **interests of minorities**.
 - _____ had famously stated: The most certain test by which we judge whether a country is really free is the amount of security enjoyed by minorities
- **Article 30:**
 - Right of minorities to **establish and administer educational institutions**.
 - Article 30 is confined only to minorities (religious or linguistic) and does not extend to any section of citizens. However, the term **minority** has **not been defined anywhere in the constitution**.
 - It speaks specifically of two categories of minorities- **religious and linguistic**.
- **Article 350-A in Part XVII:**
 - **Instruction in mother tongue:** It shall be the endeavor of every state and every local authority within the **state to provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother-tongue** at the primary stage of education to children belonging to linguistic minority groups
- **Article 350B:**
 - There shall be a **Special Officer for linguistic minorities** to be appointed by the President.
 - It shall be the duty of the Special Officer to **investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for linguistic minorities under this Constitution** and **report to the President** upon those matters at such intervals as the President may direct, and the President shall cause all such **reports to be laid before each House of Parliament**, and sent to the Governments of the States concerned.
 - This provision was initially not part of the Constitution of India, 1950. It was inserted by the Constitution **(Seventh Amendment) Act, 1956**

Who are religious minorities?

A religious minority is a group of people whose religion is minority or **the religion held by a minority of a population in a country**. Initially five religious communities, viz., **Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists and Zoroastrians (Parsis)** were notified as minority communities by the Union Government. Further vide notification dated 27th January 2014, **Jains** were also notified as another minority community.



Problems of Religious Minorities:

1. **Problem of Identity:** Because of the difference in **socio cultural practices, history and background, minorities have to grapple with the issue of identity**. This gives rise to the problems of adjustment with the majority community.
2. **Problems of Security:** Different identities and their small number relative to the rest of society develop **feelings of insecurity** about their life, assets and well-being. This sense of insecurity may get accentuated at times when **relations between the majority and the minority communities in a society** are strained or not very cordial.
3. **Problem related to equity:** The minority community in **social spheres may remain deprived** of the benefit of opportunities of development as a result of discrimination. Because of differences in identity, the minority community develops the perception of a **sense of inequity**.
 - _____
 - _____
 - _____
4. **Problem of Communal Tension and Riots:** The problem of communal tension and riots remains a significant concern for religious minorities in India.
 - Eg: The incidents such as the **2013 Muzaffarnagar riots**, which resulted in widespread violence and displacement, underscoring the vulnerability of minority communities to inter-religious conflicts over the past decade.
 - Such incidents, though **sporadic**, do occur and are a **great source of fear and concern** for religious minorities.
 - **2002 Godhra Riots:** The burning of a train in Godhra on 27 February 2002, which caused the deaths of 69 Hindu pilgrims returning from Ayodhya triggered the violence.
5. **Lack of Sufficient representation in civil service and politics:**
 - The lack of sufficient representation in civil service and politics hinders the equitable participation of religious minorities in India's democratic processes, with instances such as the disproportionately **low representation of minorities in key administrative positions and political offices** over the past decade, highlighting this systemic challenge.
 - _____ highlighted that- while **Muslims** constitute **14%** of the Indian population, they only comprise **2.5% of the Indian bureaucracy and 5% in politics**
6. **Politicization of Religious issues:**
 - The issue of religious minority rights is a contentious one in India, where there have been some instances of discrimination against minorities. It is important for the government and other institutions to ensure that the rights of all citizens, regardless of their religion, are protected and respected.
 - **Case Study: Karnataka Hijab Controversy (2022):**
 - In **February 2022**, Muslim students in a Karnataka junior college were **denied entry for wearing hijabs**, sparking protests.
 - In response, Hindu students counter-protested by wearing **saffron scarves**.
 - The Karnataka government subsequently directed that **uniforms be worn without exceptions**, citing institutional discipline.
 - Multiple petitions were filed in court. On **15 March 2022**, the Karnataka High Court **upheld the ban**, ruling that the hijab is *not an essential religious practice* in Islam.
 - The decision was widely criticized by global figures and organizations, including **Malala Yousafzai** and **Human Rights Watch**, who saw it as a violation of women's rights and freedom of religion.
7. **Fear mongering by the majority community:**
 - Fear mongering by majority groups often perpetuates **social tension, discrimination, and communal polarization**.
 - In recent years, several events in India illustrate how political and social narratives can be used to construct insecurity about minorities, especially Muslims.
 - **Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and Shaheen Bagh Protests:**
 - The **CAA 2019** was criticized for explicitly excluding Muslims from fast-tracked citizenship provisions.
 - Media narratives and political speeches often painted Muslim protesters (like the women of Shaheen Bagh) as "anti-national" or "funded by outsiders," feeding majoritarian fear about minority assertion.
 - This ambiguity created suspicion against Muslims instead of focusing on constitutional concerns.



Important cases relating to Religious Minorities:

- _____'s PIL:
 - The court had said **no new religious group** was to be recognised as a minority and the NCM must work towards reducing the list of religious minorities, and finally doing away with it altogether. This is a call for assimilation. Our Constitution wants integration, not assimilation.

Major Recommendations by _____ are the following:

- With regard to Quota, the commission says that **10% should be reserved for muslims and 5%** for other minorities in Central and State Government jobs in all cadres and Grades.
- Since **Minorities constitute 8.4% of total OBC population**, according to the Mandal commission report, so in the **27% OBC quota, an 8.4% sub-quota** should be earmarked for Minorities.
- The Internal Breakup should be **6% for the Muslims** commensurate with their 73% share in total minority population, at the national level and **2.4% for other minorities**.
- Reservation now extended to the scheduled tribes, which is a **religion neutral class**, should be carefully examined to assess the **extent of minority presence in it and take remedial measures**.
- **Scheduled caste status for dalits in all religions:** It recommends **delinking of scheduled caste status from religion** and **abrogation of 1950 scheduled caste order** which "still excludes Muslims, Christians, Jains and Parsis from the SC net" and only includes "Hindus, Buddhists and Sikhs".

Way forward:

- Apart from the above recommendations, establishment of **Morarji Desai Residential Schools and PU colleges** for minorities at taluk level, and **minority women employees hostels, minority women degree colleges** for their socio-economic development.
- [Morarji Desai Residential Schools for Minorities are the schools in Karnataka state in India. These are run by the **Directorate of Minorities department of the Government of Karnataka**. The schools are set up to provide free residential education from Standards VI to X to the students from minority communities.]

Linguistic minorities:**Who are linguistic minorities?**

A linguistic minority is a group of people whose mother tongue is different from that of the majority in the state or part of a state. Thus, **linguistic minorities are determined on a state-wide basis**.

Important cases relating to Linguistic Minorities:

- It was in 1971, in the case of _____, and other cases, that the Supreme Court of India defined a linguistic minority as a **minority that at least has a spoken language, regardless of having a script or not**.
- In the case of _____, it further held that the **status of linguistic minority is to be determined in the context of states and not India as a whole**.

Problems of Linguistic Minorities:

1. Not enough funds deployed to teach the **minority's minority language in schools**.
 - _____ points out that the reasons for extremely low literacy rates among the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups are **poor educational infrastructure, poorly trained teachers, lack of teaching in the tribal languages and completely irrelevant curriculum**
 - The report acknowledges that the changing educational scenario can push many of the **tribal languages into extinction** and provides that **education in mother tongue in the primary level of education needs to be encouraged**.
2. **Language Diversity:** India is home to a vast array of linguistic communities, with so many major languages and numerous dialects.
 - Linguistic minorities often face **challenges in preserving and promoting their languages** due to the **dominance of major languages**.
 - Difficulty in learning **in primary schools as instruction in mother tongue** for these children doesn't always happen.
 - A study points out – As many of the schools for Tribal Groups are witnessing a **sudden shift to English medium of instruction**, students belonging to the indigenous linguistic minorities are facing the brunt of it as they **cannot understand their curriculum and are also losing their own language**.
3. Having to use the **majority's language for redress of Grievances**.
 - Linguistic minorities in India often face the challenge of having to use the majority's language for redress of grievances, creating a **barrier to effective communication and representation**.
4. **Social Discrimination** – made to feel like outsiders at times.
 - Social discrimination against linguistic minorities frequently results in them **feeling like outsiders**, as seen in instances where individuals speaking regional languages are marginalized in social and professional settings.



5. **Cultural Erosion:** The influence of major languages and cultures can lead to the erosion of unique linguistic and cultural identities within minority communities. This poses a challenge to the preservation of diverse cultural heritage.
6. **Economic Disparities:** Linguistic minorities may experience economic disparities as economic opportunities often correlate with proficiency in major languages. This creates a disadvantage for those whose primary language is not widely spoken.

Conclusion:

A civilisation can be judged by the way it treats its minorities. We must empower minority communities through **affirmative action, inclusive development**, and equitable share in **education, employment, and economy**. Implementing the **Justice Ranganath Mishra Commission** recommendations can ensure their **upliftment** and strengthen India's **diverse character**.

Paper 2- Chapter – 4

GROWTH OF ANTHROPOLOGY IN INDIA

The course of development of anthropological thought and study in India was **slow but steady**. Some other anthropologists differ in their opinion regarding the time span of these periods but the generally accepted periods of anthropology are as follows.

Formative phase (1774– 1919):

- During this period the emphasis of anthropological studies was on tribal life and the diversity of their customs in India.
 - Many handbooks, ethnographies, gazettes on tribes and castes were published.
 - In addition to the ethnographic reports, revenue reports of **Dalton, Buchanon, and Lord Baden Powell** also examined the socio-cultural situation of India during this period.
- The foundation of **Asiatic Society of India** by _____ in 1774 was an important landmark during this period. This became the **Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1784**. By this time, the society also **started publishing its journal** regularly.
- Some other individual efforts were also initiated during this phase. _____ **published his report on the Tribes and Castes of Bengal in 1891**. Later he became the Head of Census operations and conducted **ethnographic surveys in India**.

Contribution of Indian anthropologists:

- In 1912 _____ published the _____ monograph _____ and wrote on other tribes of Central India as well.

The Constructive Phase (1920–1949):

- Anthropology had been introduced as a **subject in the Sociology Department of Bombay University in 1919**. Anthropology also came into the **curriculum of Post-graduate studies** in Calcutta University by 1920.
- Another remarkable step during this period was the publication of the journal _____ in 1921, under the editorship of _____.
- The **25th Indian Science Congress** was held at Calcutta in 1938 and the focal theme was _____
 - Anthropology in India'. A joint session of the **Indian Science Congress Association and the British Association** reviewed the progress of anthropology in India. This was the first review of anthropological research in India.
- In 1939, _____ **published his book** _____. In this book he had proposed that the **tribes should be left alone** and they should be allowed to develop in **isolation**, away from the mainstream.
- The need for a full-fledged anthropological research organisation was fulfilled by **establishing the Anthropological Survey of India in 1945**. _____ **was the first Director of this institution at Calcutta**.

The Analytical Phase (1950–1990):

- By this time, Indian anthropologists started regularly interacting with foreign (American) anthropologists. Many kinds of collaborative works were taken up. Moreover, during this period, there was a **shift from the descriptive studies of preliterate societies to the analytical studies of complex societies**.
- Some **anthropologists from abroad** came to India to conduct research. Their works created a momentum for anthropological research in India. The villages they studied became famous. **A large number of village study monographs were published in the 1950s and 1960s. Mention Redfield, Singer, Marriott and other village studies examples.** These studies helped to generate new concepts and ideas.
- During this period, some anthropologists developed a distinct research methodology to conduct their studies.



- **L. P. Vidyarthi** (using the analytical concepts to study **sacred complexes, nature-man-spirit complex** in tribal societies etc).

Evaluative Phase (1990 to the Present):

- During recent times **new areas of Anthropology and different subfields** within these areas have been emerging.
- Interest in **Medical Anthropology, Religion, Development studies and Psychological studies** are more evident.
- Numerous papers have been published by Anthropologists in India concerning
 - change leading to **tribal identity, integration, vanishing culture and planning**
 - emergence of **industrial Anthropology**,
 - increased emphasis on tribal demography.
 - integrated study of tribal religions.
- Important contributions have been made to **Action Research, Socio-Psychological Research, and Folk-lore researches, Studies of Power Structure and Leadership and Anthropology of Religion**.

The growth of anthropology in India passed through **formative, constructive, analytical, and evaluative phases**, moving from documenting indigenous traditions to critically analysing theories and methods. Today, it remains a **dynamic and relevant discipline**, continually adapting to India's changing socio-cultural realities.

5.3. Panchayati Raj and Social Change

- The Panchayati Raj Institutions play a major role in the socio and economic **development of people at the grassroot level**.
- **Historical Background:**
 - India has had a long tradition of panchayats in one form or another.
 - In the olden days, the inhabitants of a village used to meet together under the leadership of village elders to discuss and resolve village problems.
- **What is social change?**
 - Any major change in behaviour patterns, cultural values, and customs over time is referred to as social change.
 - **By "significant" modification**, anthropologists mean changes yielding **profound** social consequences.
 - _____ - Social change involves **alteration in the structure and functioning** of societal forms or processes themselves.
 - _____ - Social change refers to **changes in values, institutions and practices** of society.
- **What is a Panchayat?**
 - Panchayati Raj is the **oldest system of local government** in the Indian subcontinent.
 - Panchayati Raj Institutions have **existed as local government units in India for a long time**, in many forms and combinations.
- The Panchayati Raj Institution (PRI) consists of **three levels**:
 - Gram Panchayat at the village level
 - Block Panchayat or Panchayat Samiti at the intermediate level
 - Zilla Panchayat at the district level
- **Some pointers about Panchayats**
 - The word **"Panchayat"** means **assembly (ayat) of five (panch)** and **raj** means **"rule"**.
 - Panchayats are a **group of elders** chosen by the local community to settle disputes between individuals and villages. The leader of the panchayat used to be called as **Mukhya or Sarpanch**.
 - It is also recognised as a **type of direct democracy** (i.e they exercise all the powers of a government at a village level).

Panchayati Raj and Social Change:

- **Leadership from less privileged sections of society as Social Change:**
 - Since **all eligible voters of the village can participate** in the Gram Sabha, it is a **channel to include the less privileged section** of society in the governance process.
 - Further, the state legislature shall provide for the reservation of offices of chairperson in the panchayat at the village or any other level for the SCs and STs.
 - **Women reservation:**
 - **Bihar** became the first state to reserve **50% panchayat seats for women**, and was followed by 15 others, including Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Kerala, Tripura and Maharashtra.
 - Despite the advances, however, challenges remain. On **National Panchayati Raj Day on 24 April**, Prime Minister Narendra Modi asked that the idea of **"sarpanch pati"**, or the husband of a woman sarpanch calling the shots, be quashed for good.



- **Tribals and Social Change:**
 - The **PESA** is a bold statement addressing issues such as the tribals' customary rights, cultural rights, language and identity, in addition to rights to all resources within their domain such as land, water, forests and minerals, among others.
 - The Act emphasizes the **right of tribal people to maintain and strengthen their own institutions, cultures and traditions and to pursue their development in accordance with their aspirations and needs.**
- **Other social change initiatives:**
 - **Tracking health outcomes** such as preventing childhood malnutrition, providing nutritious food to pregnant women living below the poverty line, and ensuring no deaths or injuries during childbirth.
 - **Other government programmes** include **promoting social peace**, raising farmer welfare, enhancing **rural development**, offering urban utilities to villages, working towards **open-defecation-free communities**, and **ensuring sufficient toilets for women in villages** are all Panchayati Raj activities.

Case studies:

- **Ban on Alcohol consumption:**
 - Two villages in Rajasthan have voted overwhelmingly for **permanent closure of liquor shops following a prolonged campaign launched by women** against alcohol consumption.
 - The statutory rules lay down that if 51% of the registered voters in the village panchayat opt for closure of a liquor shop, it has to shut down.
 - In 2015, the **ladies of Rajsamand's Bhim tehsil** launched a campaign against drinking by presenting a memorandum to the district administration asking the closure of liquor shops in the villages of Barar and Hamela Ki Ver.
- **Panchayati raj and Decentralized planning:**
 - For Latak in **Assam's Dhemaji district**, floods are a living reality.
 - But this remote village of about 300 houses has found a novel cost effective way to connect flood-affected areas – a bridge made out of neatly stacked bamboo.
 - It may not sound like a big success story but, for the village panchayat, it is a cause for much celebration.
 - The **panchayat planned the project** after deliberations with villagers and **funded it from its own resources: an example of complete decentralisation of planning.**
- **Social welfare:**
 - The panchayat of Digampur village in West Bengal has involved in social welfare activities such as:
 - 'Direct-to-home' drinking water supply,
 - doorstep garbage collection,
 - handicrafts from organic manure etc..
 - For this, the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj** awarded this gram panchayat with the **first prize** under its **Gram Panchayat Vikas Yojana** for instituting far-reaching changes.
- **Panchayats in Environment conservation:**
 - The Gram Panchayats in Odisha carried out **plantation activities in 2020–2021.**
 - It is an ideal measure in distressed times such as the COVID-19 pandemic for immediate **income generation** for returnees, **expanding green cover and mitigating climate change.**
 - The **Panchayat plantation programme**, however, can be termed as non-participatory and nothing less than a firm bureaucratic top-down approach, instead of **meaningful collaboration of villagers throughout the programme cycle and beyond.**
- **Panchayats and social development:**
 - In a survey conducted by **ACNielsen ORG-MARG** for the **ministry of Panchayati Raj**, it was found that the elected representatives of panchayats are strongly taking up social issues such as:
 - Discouragement of child marriage
 - The problem of gambling
 - alcoholism etc..

The intent and vision for panchayats to play a **proactive role in nation-building and driving social change are in place. All that the country needs now is efficient implementation.**

Panchayati Raj is not just local governance but a tool of **social change**. It empowers **marginalised groups**, promotes **health, education, and development**, and safeguards **tribal rights** through laws like **PESA**. By decentralising power, it drives **inclusive growth** and strengthens **grassroots democracy** in rural India.



Media and Social Change

- What is media?
 - _____ said – “**The medium is the message**”, meaning **media** not only carries information but **shapes** how people **think & act**, directly influencing **social change**.
 - **It is the main means of mass communication.**
 - **Types of Media:**
 - **Print Media:** Newspapers, magazines, pamphlets (traditional but still influential).
 - **Broadcast Media:** Radio and television (reach wide audiences quickly).
 - **Digital Media:** Internet, social media, online platforms (instant and interactive).
- What is social change?
 - Any major change in behaviour patterns, cultural values, and customs over time is referred to as social change.
 - **By “significant” modification**, anthropologists mean changes yielding **profound** social consequences.
 - _____ – Social change involves **alteration in the structure and functioning** of societal forms or processes themselves.
 - _____ – Social change refers to **changes in values, institutions and practices** of society.

Impact of Media:

- **Positive Impacts:**
 - **Giving voice to people:**
 - **Eg:** The agitation of _____, against the attempts of **Vedanta** to **conduct Bauxite mining** in the **Niyamgiri range**, was widely popularized by the media. This resulted in a **Supreme Court order** on April 18, 2013, which gave a clear direction that mining clearance can only be given if Dongriag agreed to the project.
 - **Awareness about wrongs:**
 - The media is like a **mirror to the world** which **reflects the true and harsh realities of the world**, as media is being trusted by everyone and people always trust actual and honest news. The media has its own opinion but they can publish it in their editorials where the public can assess it.
 - **Eg:** Coverage of **Honour killings, khap panchayats, lynchings**, by media, have helped in mobilising funds for clamping them down.
 - **Uplifting of marginal sections:**
 - Uplifting communities like Ghasi (Scheduled caste community of Odisha) by preventing social discrimination
 - **Functioning of FRA 2006:** Rejection of appeals at patwari level, revealed the loopholes in laws and led it to its quick redressal.
 - **#Metoo movement,**
 - **#Black lives Matter**
 - **Media and its role in revival of dying languages:**
 - Using **mobile radio**, _____ has been spreading the popularity of the language within their geographical limits.
 - “The **Asur language** figures in the list of **UNESCO Interactive Atlas of the World’s Languages in Danger**. Only 7,000 to 8,000 Asur tribes are left in the community who are well conversant in the language. So, we are trying our best to save our language from vanishing,” said _____, who has been at the forefront of community efforts to preserve the language.
 - **Radio programmes** are based on incidents happening in different parts of the world and also news relating to the community.
 - **Media and women empowerment:**
 - Through online groups, social media offers amazing opportunities for women to establish sincere connections with the outside world.
 - _____ concluded in her study “**Impact of Mass Media on Women: A Sociological Study of Gulbarga District**” that the impact of mass media on women has enabled their empowerment, by improving learning and knowledge, advocating **equal status of women (gender equality)** etc.
 - **Media and democracy:**
 - It ensures that citizens make **responsible, informed choices** rather than acting out of ignorance or misinformation.
 - Second, information serves a “**checking function**” by ensuring that elected representatives **uphold their oaths of office** and carry out the wishes of those who elected them.



- **Media and social justice:**
 - The media can serve as an important instrument in achieving social justice by **educating, raising awareness and questioning caste discrimination.**
- **Negative impacts:**
 - **Dangers to Socialization:**
 - We remain fixed to TV screens at the **cost of socialization.**
 - We cut short our social activities just to watch some favourite programmes on TV.
 - We are not undertaking socialization / giving time to our kids, parents, etc because we are glued to TV etc. This is developing a generation gap.
 - **Fake news:** creating tensions between different communities.
 - **Yellow Journalism: or Sensationalism of news** led to unbalanced and biased opinions.
 - Former Chief Justice of India N.V. Ramana, citing that the media is running "**kangaroo courts**", said that **ill-informed, biased and agenda-driven debates** in the media on issues pending in courts are affecting justice delivery.
 - **Distortion of free and fair elections due to paid news.**
 - **Media and diet patterns:**
 - mass media plays in the development of male and female body attitudes regarding **ideal body images** and how this may in turn have an impact on their mental health.
 - **Negative lifestyle:**
 - **Eg: Junk food consumption.**
 - **Media and criminal justice system:**
 - Given the media's ability to **shape political opinion**, law enforcement agencies are sometimes **under pressure** to selectively reveal certain facets of the investigation or to mischaracterize incidents as communal or systemic.
 - Just a few years ago, the investigation of the **Bhima Koregaon violence (2018)** was marked by a slew of **motivated arrests** of popular dissenters critical of the Government.
 - **Disha (Priyanka Reddy) murder case, 2019:** Media houses organized a rally in the name of "**JUSTICE FOR DISHA**" across two Telugu states against the incident in their own way and **demanded severe punishment like hanging and encounter.** Finally, All the four accused in the kidnap, rape and murder of Disha were killed in an **alleged 'encounter' by police** early on 6th December, 2019

Media is both a **mirror** and a **motor of social change**. It **informs, empowers, and challenges social hierarchies**, while also **shaping new values and practices**. Despite risks like **fake news**, its role in **democracy, social justice, and cultural transformation** makes it a **central driver of change** in contemporary society.

Chapter 5.1- Indian Village

VILLAGE STUDY IN INDIAN AND ITS SIGNIFICANCE

Village studies in anthropology in India involve **in-depth investigations** into the **social, cultural, economic, and political dynamics** of rural communities. Anthropologists conduct **fieldwork** to understand the **intricate relationships, traditional practices, and socio-economic structures** within villages, providing valuable insights into the **diverse and complex fabric** of Indian rural life. These studies contribute to a deeper comprehension of the dynamics shaping village societies, offering a **holistic perspective** on the intersections of **tradition and modernity** in the Indian context.

1. Diversity of Indian Villages

Indian villages exhibit a significant degree of **internal and external diversity**, characterized by **complex social relationships and institutional structures**.

(Different Views on Indian Villages)

- **Mahatma Gandhi:** Said "*India lives in its villages.*" For him, the village was **autonomous, self-sufficient, and moral**, representing authentic and sustainable life.
- **Jawaharlal Nehru:** Did not romanticize villages. He saw them as sites of **backwardness, poverty, and stagnation**, and believed India's future lay in **industrialization and modernization**.
- **B.R. Ambedkar:** Was highly critical. He called villages "**a sink of localism, a den of ignorance, and a place of oppression**", pointing to caste discrimination and marginalization of Dalits.)

2. Chicago School's Impact (1950s-60s)

Influential anthropologists from the **Chicago School**, including **Robert Redfield, Milton Singer, and McKim Marriott**, played a pivotal role in shaping the **theoretical and methodological foundations** of Indian village studies during the 1950s and 60s.

3. Concept of Village Study

Village studies involve selecting a **specific village** as a **unit of investigation**, providing **ethnographic insights** through **participant observation**. **Redfield** introduced the **analytical concept of village India**.



4. Historical Background

In the 1930s, **William Wiser** published works like *Hindu Jajmani System* and *Behind the Mud Walls*, contributing to the **historical background** of village studies.

5. D.N. Majumdar's Contribution

D.N. Majumdar's *Caste and Communication in an Indian Village* illustrated the impact of **new means of transport and communication** on **caste mobility**.

6. S.C. Dube's Classic Village Study

S.C. Dube's *Indian Village* is considered a **classic** in village studies, providing valuable insights into the **social dynamics** of rural India.

7. Oscar Lewis's Work on Rural Cosmopolitanism

Oscar Lewis explored **Rural Cosmopolitanism**, adding another dimension to the understanding of **village life** in India.

Significance of Village Study:

1. Theoretical Level

- **Dominant Caste (M.N. Srinivas)**: Explores the **influential caste** within a village.
- **Sanskritization and Westernization (M.N. Srinivas)**: Ideas on **cultural changes** driven by **emulation of higher castes** and **Western influences**.
- **Little Republics vs. Rural Cosmopolitanism**: Contrasts between **Charles Metcalfe's "Little Republics"** and **Oscar Lewis's "Rural Cosmopolitanism"** highlight diverse **village social structures**.
- **Little and Great Traditions (Robert Redfield)**: Distinguishes between **local village traditions** and **broader cultural influences**.
- **Universalization and Parochialization (McKim Marriott)**: Explores the **tension** between **universal** and **local values**.
- **Sacred Complex (L.P. Vidyarthi)**: Concept of **interconnectedness of religious beliefs** in the village.
- **Nature-Man-Spirit Complex (L.P. Vidyarthi)**: Exploration of the **relationship between nature, humanity, and spirituality**, contributing to theoretical richness.

Village studies, therefore, not only provide a **nuanced understanding** of the **social dynamics** at the village level but also contribute to the development of **theoretical frameworks** that shape the broader field of **anthropology in India**.

2. APPLIED LEVEL: (This will be discussed in detail in the subsequent topics.)

Village studies also helped in **policy and planning**.

Example 1: Community Development Programs (1950s onwards)

- India launched community development blocks for rural progress.
- Village studies showed a problem: if ₹1 crore was given for development, it often went first to **dominant caste hamlets**.
- Roads, wells, and electricity poles appeared in upper caste areas, while Dalit hamlets remained neglected.
- This highlighted how **inequality can grow despite development schemes**.

Example 2: Tribal Development Programs

- The **Tribal Sub-Plan (1974)** aimed to funnel funds to tribal communities.
- Anthropologists showed how non-tribal intermediaries often captured benefits.
- For example, in Madhya Pradesh and Odisha, contractors or moneylenders took over schemes meant for tribal welfare.

Example 3: Barriers to Social Change

- **George Foster's concept of "Traditional Culture"**: societies glorify their past and resist change.
- Example: Public toilets under government schemes often failed in villages because **caste prejudices** made people refuse to share bathrooms.
- Similarly, some resisted co-education in schools because of traditional gender norms.

Village studies in India bridged **theory** and **practice**, enriching **anthropology** with concepts like **dominant caste** and **Sanskritization**, while also guiding **planners** in **rural development**. They remain vital in understanding the **pulse of rural India**, where **tradition** and **modernity** continue to intersect.



INDIAN VILLAGES – CHANGE IN PATTERNS OF SETTLEMENTS

Rural Settlement Patterns in India:

India's rural settlements are diverse because they are shaped by geography, culture, security, and economic needs. The patterns vary from one region to another.

Factors Responsible for Different Types of Rural Settlements:

1. Physical Features:

- **Altitude, climate, and water availability** directly influence where people live.
- In the **Himalayas**, villages are clustered in valleys to use fertile land and avoid harsh weather.
- In **arid regions like Rajasthan**, settlements are scattered around oases and wells due to scarce water.

2. Cultural and Ethnic Factors

- **Caste, religion, and social structure** shape settlement patterns.
- Some communities prefer to live close together based on cultural ties.
- In **South India**, villages often develop around temples, creating a sense of identity and community.

3. Security Considerations

- In areas prone to **raids, thefts, or invasions**, people lived in **clustered and fortified villages** for protection.
- Examples can be seen in **fortified villages and forts** across different regions of India.

4. Economic Factors

- Proximity to **agricultural land, trade routes, or coasts** also influences settlements.
- **Fertile plains** → agrarian settlements.
- **Coastal areas** → fishing villages.
- **Market routes** → settlements near trade centres.

Thus, Rural settlement patterns in India reflect an interplay of **geography, culture, security, and economy**. Together, these factors have shaped the **unique rural landscape** of India over centuries.

Different Types of Rural Settlements:

Rural settlements in India can broadly be put into four types:

1. Clustered, agglomerated Or nucleated
2. Semi-clustered Or fragmented
3. Hamleted
4. Dispersed or isolated.

1. Clustered Settlements:

The clustered rural settlement is a **compact or closely built area of houses**. In this type of village the general living area is distinct and separated from the surrounding farms, barns and pastures. Such settlements are generally found in **fertile alluvial plains and in the northeastern states**. Sometimes, people live in compact villages for **security or defense reasons**.

Regions: Bundelkhand region of central India and in Nagaland.

In Rajasthan – scarcity of water has necessitated compact settlement for maximum utilization of available water resources.

2. Semi-Clustered Settlements:

Semi-clustered or fragmented settlements *may result from the tendency of clustering in a restricted area of dispersed settlement*. More often such a pattern may also result from **segregation or fragmentation of a large compact village**. In this case, one or more sections of the village society choose or are forced to live a *little away from the main cluster or village*.

In such cases, generally, the land-owning and dominant community occupies the central part of the main village, whereas people of **lower strata** of society and menial workers settle on the **outer flanks** of the village.

Regions: Gujarat plain and some parts of Rajasthan.

3. Hamleted Settlements:

Sometimes settlement is **fragmented into several units** physically separated from each other bearing a common name. These units are locally called **panna, para, palli, nagla, dhani**, etc. In various parts of the country, this segmentation of a large village is often motivated by social and ethnic factors.

Regions: Such villages are more frequently found in the middle and lower Ganga plain, Chhattisgarh and lower valleys of the Himalayas.

4. Dispersed Settlements:

Dispersed or isolated settlement patterns in India appear in the *form of isolated huts or hamlets of few huts in remote jungles, or on small hills with farms or pasture on the slopes*. **Extreme dispersion of settlement** is often caused by the extremely **fragmented** nature of the terrain and land resource base of habitable areas.

Regions: Many areas of Meghalaya, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Kerala have this type of settlement.



In conclusion, the varied rural settlement patterns in India, influenced by physical features, cultural and ethnic factors, and security considerations, encompass clustered settlements in fertile plains, semi-clustered formations with social stratification, hamleted configurations motivated by social and ethnic factors, and dispersed settlements dictated by the challenging terrain and land resource distribution, reflecting the diverse geographical and sociocultural landscape of the country.

Changes in Settlement Patterns:

Anthropologically, changes in rural settlement patterns in India can be analyzed through the lens of various socio-cultural factors. Here are some reasons for the change, with a focus on caste, class, jajmani system, social mobility, and modernization:

Caste Dynamics:

- Traditional rural settlement patterns in India were often influenced by the caste system, with specific areas designated for different castes. Over time, changes in social attitudes and government policies aimed at reducing caste-based discrimination have contributed to a more mixed settlement pattern.
- Increased social awareness and movements advocating for the rights of marginalized castes have challenged traditional spatial hierarchies, leading to a shift in settlement patterns.

Class and Economic Changes:

- Economic factors play a crucial role in shaping rural settlement patterns.
- Changes in agricultural practices, land reforms, and economic opportunities have led to shifts in settlement locations.
- As economic activities diversify beyond agriculture, new opportunities emerged in certain regions, attracting people and altering settlement patterns based on class and economic considerations.

Jajmani System and Occupational Changes:

- The jajmani system, a traditional economic arrangement where different castes provide specific services to others, has historically influenced settlement patterns. Changes in occupational structures, such as the decline of traditional occupations and the rise of new industries, impacted settlement locations.
- Modernization and globalization led to the erosion of the jajmani system as people seek alternative economic opportunities, contributing to changes in settlement patterns.

Social Mobility:

- Changes in social mobility, facilitated by education and access to resources, can influence where people choose to settle. Increased mobility led to the migration of individuals or families to urban or peri-urban areas for better educational and employment prospects.
- Social mobility challenged traditional settlement patterns by allowing individuals to move outside their designated caste-specific areas, contributing to a more diverse and mixed settlement landscape.

Modernization and Infrastructure Development:

- The process of modernization, marked by technological advancements and infrastructure development, can significantly impact rural settlement patterns. Improved transportation, communication, and access to amenities encouraged people to move away from isolated or less-developed areas.
- Modernization also led to the growth of market towns and urban centers, attracting populations away from traditional agrarian settlements.

Government Policies and Land Reforms:

- Government policies, particularly those related to land reforms and rural development, influenced settlement patterns. Redistribution of land, infrastructure projects, and incentivizing certain types of economic activities led to shifts in population distribution.
- Land reforms aimed at reducing landlessness and promoting equitable land distribution have altered the spatial arrangement of rural settlements.

In conclusion, the anthropological analysis of changes in rural settlement patterns in India involves considering the interplay of **caste dynamics, class structures, the jajmani system, social mobility, and the impact of modernization**. These factors collectively contribute to the dynamic and evolving nature of rural settlements in the country.



LITTLE REPUBLIC AND RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM

ARE INDIAN VILLAGES LITTLE REPUBLICS?

Earlier Perception about Indian Villages:

- Scholars like _____ described Indian villages as **self-sufficient and autonomous**.
- They believed villages managed their own affairs without depending on others, like **"Little Republics."**
- _____ famously said that Indian villages were like **tiny republics, standing firm even when kingdoms rose and fell** around them.
- _____ also admired this **local autonomy**, considering villages as miniature states capable of independent functioning.

Metcalfe's Idea of Little Republics:

1. **Self-Sufficiency and Autonomy**
 - Villages were seen as **self-reliant units**, with their own **social, economic, and political structures**.
 - They managed agriculture, cottage industries, and local needs without heavy dependence on external authorities.
2. **Social and Political Independence**
 - Villages had their own **local governance systems**, such as the **Panchayat**, which resolved disputes and managed affairs.
 - This gave them a sense of **self-governance** and reduced dependence on central authority.
3. **Role in Social Cohesion**
 - By maintaining autonomy, villages prevented the **concentration of power** in central authorities.
 - They also fostered **community solidarity** and **balanced societal structure**.

Examples

- **Panchayat System:** Village councils acted as local self-government, handling judicial and administrative matters.
- **Traditional Economy:** Agriculture and **cottage industries** made villages relatively independent. Goods and services were often exchanged within the community.

Limitations of the Concept

- Villages were **not completely isolated**.
- They engaged in **trade, communication, and cultural exchange** with nearby villages and towns.
- This shows that while there was autonomy, there was also **interconnectedness**.

Significance

- The idea of **"little republics"** is important for both **anthropology** and **political science**.
- It highlights how **local autonomy** and **self-governance** can ensure **social harmony** and prevent **excessive centralization of power**.
- At the same time, critiques by **Nehru and Ambedkar** remind us that villages were not just sites of autonomy, but also of **inequality, poverty, and caste oppression**.

ARE VILLAGES AUTONOMOUS?

Due to the fact that each village has its own power structure and a few powerful individuals, having control over the village. The **agrarian structure, the Jajmani system**, where people's needs are met through the **exchange of goods and services** and no intervention of the other villages in the working of one village may substantiate that Indian villages are **"little republics"**.

However that is not the case if we look at the socio-cultural institutions like marriage, it is very obvious that a family in a village has ties with the other village. Even the kinship is spread in many villages. The villages depend on the other villages for religious activities like pilgrimages and festivals. These aspects act as the bridge between the forming inter-village ties. This concept is called **"Rural Cosmopolitanism"**.

Oscar Lewis came up with the concept of **RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM**, with his study of **Rani Khera** near New Delhi. With this concept he went **against the "Little Republic"** concept proposed by **Charles Metcalfe**. Oscar Lewis says that villages are not **self-sufficient and independent** but they always maintain ties with other villages for their social, cultural, economic, religious and political activities.

Oscar Lewis submitted his paper in seminar on Indian villages at the university of Chicago and explained his findings:

- He says that the villages in **Mexico** are **"inward looking"**. They do not have socio-cultural ties with other villages. They follow village **endogamy** and the intervillage network is only for trade purposes.
- On the other hand, the villages in **India** form a **complex network**. These could be socio-cultural ties - marriage, economic ties - trade, religious ties - pilgrimage, political ties. He calls this phenomenon **"RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM"**.



- **Examples:** In the context of India, several examples illustrate the idea of rural cosmopolitanism:
 - **Jallikattu in Tamil Nadu:**
 - Jallikattu is a traditional bull-taming sport that takes place in the villages of Tamil Nadu during the Pongal festival.
 - It involves participants from multiple villages coming together to participate and spectate.
 - The event fosters social bonds and interactions among individuals from different villages, showcasing the interconnectedness of rural communities.
 - **Rath Yatras (Chariot Processions):**
 - Rath Yatras, such as the famous Jagannath Rath Yatra in Puri, Odisha, involve the procession of deities on elaborately decorated chariots.
 - Pilgrims and participants from various villages participate in these processions, creating a sense of shared religious and cultural identity across different rural communities.
 - **Village Fairs and Melas:**
 - Many villages in India host annual fairs and melas that attract participants and visitors from neighboring villages.
 - These events serve as platforms for cultural exchange, economic activities (trade and commerce), and social interactions, reinforcing the idea of rural cosmopolitanism.

Thus, Indian villages are not isolated “**little republics**” but **dynamic, interconnected communities** shaped by **social, economic, and cultural change**. Anthropological studies show that villagers are **active agents**, adapting and reshaping their societies, making it necessary to view villages as **complex** and **evolving social formations**.

AGRARIAN RELATIONS IN INDIAN VILLAGES

The **agrarian social structure in India** refers to the organization of rural life around **agriculture**, marked by **caste hierarchies, land ownership and tenancy patterns**, and **gender inequalities**. Land is often concentrated in the hands of a few, while most farmers are tenants or laborers. This structure shapes the **social relations, power, and livelihoods** of rural communities.

_____ posits that the agrarian social structure is contingent upon two key components:

- **technological arrangements**, which encompass the machinery and technology employed for agricultural purposes, and
- **social arrangements**, which involve the power structure, land ownership, and control.

Furthermore, as technological advancements increase, the reliance on social arrangements tends to decrease, and conversely, heightened dependence on social arrangements often coincides with a lesser reliance on advanced technology in agrarian contexts.

He also says that in some Asian societies economic and social institutions are interconnected.

Peasant society:

A peasant society, as initially conceptualized by A.L. Kroeber, is characterized by agricultural predominance, with Kroeber defining it as a “part society” signifying its reliance on a larger society across technological, economic, political, administrative, religious, and moral spheres; within these peasant societies, social structures are intricately woven into the fabric of caste and class relationships.

Daniel Thorner classifies this society into 3 parts

1. Proprietors/ Landowners/ Malik.
2. Working peasants/ Kisan/ Tenants
3. Laborer/ Mazdoor.

1. Maliks (Proprietors or Landowners)

- a. Mostly **rich upper-caste groups** owning large tracts of land.
- b. They held dominant power in rural society.
- c. **Examples:** Zamindars and Jagirdars before independence.

2. Kisans (Working Peasants or Tenants)

- a. Belongs largely to **middle castes** in the hierarchy.
- b. Some were **small landowners**, while others worked as **tenants** leasing land from Maliks.
- c. Considered the “**backbone of cultivation**” in Indian agriculture.

3. Mazdoors (Agricultural Laborers)

- a. Mostly **landless workers** from **lower castes**.
- b. Dependent on **wages, sharecropping, or casual labor** on Malik and Kisan lands.
- c. Occupied the lowest rung of the agrarian social structure.



This social structure which was highly dominant has seen significant decline post independence due to **social mobility** and **depeasantization** which has given rise to other new powerful classes and castes.

D.N. Dhanangre (1983) says that although Thorner's categories and subcategories are nearer the realities of the Indian agrarian social structure, there is still a need to regroup these categories into such a **broader** and more **comprehensive model** and redesignate them into commonly used concepts and criteria in the study of peasant societies. Such a model can be drawn from the works of **Lenin and Mao**, especially those relating to the analysis of agrarian classes in the **Russian** and **Chinese** societies respectively:

- **Landlords** – large landowners, often not cultivating themselves.
- **Rich peasants** – owned enough land to hire laborers.
- **Middle peasants** – small landholders, usually working with their own family labor.
- **Poor peasants** – very small plots, often dependent on others.
- **Landless laborers** – had no land at all, survived on daily wage labor.

He further opines that the social composition of these agrarian classes in terms of specific status groups like **castes, religious or ethnic groups**, etc. is far too **complex** in different regions of India to reduce into any simplistic formulae. However, for a loose and broad classification that may hold ground.

Social Stratification in Agrarian Societies of India:

- For instance, individuals classified as '**landlords and rich landowners**,' which includes non-cultivating urban money lenders/owners, were predominantly affiliated with upper castes such as **Brahmin, Thakur, or Banias in northern India**. In **Andhra Pradesh**, examples include the **Kammas, Reddis, and Raos**, in **Mysore**, the **Okkaligas and Lingayat**, the **Patidar** in the **Gujarat** region, and the **Kunbi Marathas and Deshmukhs in Maharashtra**.
- The category of '**middle and poor peasantry**,' largely burdened by debt, primarily comprised individuals from traditional castes of cultivators, artisans, and the like.
- '**Landless laborers**,' predominantly associated with untouchable castes or the scheduled castes, constituted a significant portion of this group.

Changes in agrarian social structure in india:

Changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been happening gradually over the years. Some of the key changes include:

- **Land reforms:** India has implemented various land reforms over the years, aimed at redistributing land ownership and reducing the concentration of land in the hands of a few. These reforms have helped to increase the number of small and marginal farmers and reduce the influence of large landowners.
- **Tenancy patterns:** Tenancy laws have been amended to provide better protection to tenants and improve their access to credit and other resources. This has helped to reduce the power imbalance between landlords and tenants.
- **Caste-based hierarchies:** While caste-based hierarchies still exist in many rural areas, social mobility has increased due to improvements in education and economic opportunities. This has helped to reduce the influence of caste in determining social status and economic opportunities.
- **Gender-based inequalities:** Women's participation in agriculture and access to resources has improved over the years, due to various government policies and programs aimed at promoting gender equality in rural areas.

Overall, changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been slow and incremental, but they have helped to address some of the key issues related to land ownership, tenancy patterns, caste-based hierarchies, and gender-based inequalities. There is still a long way to go in terms of promoting social change and development in rural areas, but these changes are a step in the right direction

Reasons for changes in agrarian social structure in India:

There are several reasons for the changes in agrarian social structure in India. Some of the key reasons include:

- **Government policies:** The Indian government has implemented various policies and programs aimed at promoting land reforms, improving tenancy patterns, and advancing gender equality in rural areas. These policies have had a significant impact on the agrarian social structure in India.
- **Economic factors:** Economic changes, such as the growth of non-agricultural industries and the rise of the service sector, have led to a decline in the importance of agriculture as a source of livelihood. This has led to changes in land ownership patterns and increased the number of small and marginal farmers.
- **Social factors:** Social changes, such as improvements in education and increased mobility, have led to changes in caste-based hierarchies and increased social mobility.
- **Technological advances:** Technological advances, such as improved irrigation systems and farm machinery, have led to changes in agricultural practices and increased productivity. This has led to changes in land ownership patterns and increased the number of small and medium-sized farms.

Overall, the changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been driven by a combination of government policies, economic and social factors, and technological advances. These changes have helped to address some of the key issues related to land ownership, tenancy patterns, caste-based hierarchies, and gender-based inequalities in rural areas.



IMPACT OF GLOBALIZATION ON INDIAN VILLAGES

Globalization is the **process by which the world is becoming increasingly interconnected as a result of massively increased trade and cultural exchange**. It has accelerated since the 18th century due to advances in transportation and communication technology.

- **Anthony Giddens** describes it as the **gradual integration of economies and societies** across the world.
- In short, globalization refers to the **interconnectedness and interdependence** of nations, cultures, and communities at a global scale.

Indian Villages– Pre Globalization:

Villages are the centers of self-sufficiency, embodiment of collectivism. Indian villages mostly followed the pre-literate and early methods of **Economic practices** which contributed to the well-founded **social relations** between different caste people. Jajmani system is one such example.

Impact of Globalization on Indian Villages:

- **Major Trends in Village Economy:**
 - _____:
 - Four major trends include
 - the transformation from subsistence to surplus economy,
 - introduction of modern technology,
 - abolition of intermediaries like Zamindars, and
 - the emergence of associations and institutions linked with urban and national organizations.
- **Transformation of Agrarian Relations:**
 - **Chand and Srivastava's Study (2014 – Jamgod Village, Madhya Pradesh):**
 - Traditional agrarian relations favoring the local dominant caste have been disrupted, leading to a shift towards contract-based employment over traditional payment in kind.
- **Depeasantization and Change in Status Calculations:**
 - **Tilche's Study (Patidars of Sundarana Village, Gujarat):**
 - Globalization has enabled Patidars, a traditional agricultural community, to free themselves from agriculture through education, employment, and emigration to urban areas, reshaping their status calculations.
- **Emergence of New Conflicts and Changes in Traditional Practices:**
 - **Simpson's Analysis (2016) of Various Village Studies:**
 - Market economy and education have given rise to conflicts between agricultural and non-agricultural ways of life, leading to the decline of the jajmani system and a reduced appeal for Sanskritisation.
- **Disruption of Joint Families:**
 - _____'s Observation (Weakening of Ties):
 - Globalization has contributed to the disruption of joint families in Indian villages.
- **Decline in Jajmani System:**
 - The **JAJMANI SYSTEM** is one of practices which was greatly hit by globalization and rarely observed today in some rural areas.
 - **William Wiser's Definition:**
 - The Jajmani system, where each caste group provides standardized services to other castes, has declined due to factors such as the **role of the state, technological innovations, and political mobilization**.
- **Impact on Social Customs and Traditions:**
 - The westernization of culture through global media has eroded traditional values and customs, questioning age-old practices.
- **Impact on Agriculture:**
 - Globalization has facilitated mobility and connectivity, leading to rapid migration for employment outside the agricultural sector.
 - Agricultural tools and practices have evolved with mechanization, improved seeds, fertilizers, and pesticides, benefiting big, rich farmers.

In conclusion, the impact of globalization on Indian village societies is multifaceted, encompassing transformations in **agrarian relations, depeasantization, changes in status calculations, the emergence of new conflicts, disruption of traditional practices, and the decline of systems like the Jajmani system**. The shift towards a surplus economy, introduction of modern technology, and changes in social customs and agriculture reflect the intricate dynamics through which global forces have reshaped and challenged the traditional fabric of village life in India.



INDIAN VILLAGE AS A SOCIAL SYSTEM:

System implies an **orderly arrangement, inter-relationship** of parts in which every part has a fixed place and definite role. These parts do not exist in isolation but are bound by a **constant interaction**. When this understanding of the system is applied to the Social System, we get an insight into the working of the social system.

Social system is the **patterned** series of **interrelationships** existing between **individuals, groups, and institutions** and forming a coherent whole.

According to _____, "Social system consists of a plurality of social actors engaged in more or less stable **interaction** according to **shared cultural norms and meaning**".

He further adds:

- Here the interaction is '**patterned interaction**'.
- It takes under its orbit all the diverse **sub-systems** such as economic, political, religious and others.

Key Features of a Social System:

- **Plurality of Individual Actors:**
 - Implies the necessity of multiple interacting individuals within the system.
 - Eg: The Indian village comprises a diverse population engaged in various social roles, including individuals from different castes, occupations, and age groups, contributing to the plurality of social actors within the village.
- **Aims and Objectives:**
 - Every social system must possess specific aims and objectives, avoiding aimlessness.
 - Eg: Like any social system, an Indian village is not aimless; it pursues specific aims and objectives. These objectives may involve maintaining social harmony, preserving cultural traditions, and ensuring the well-being of its members.
- **Order and Pattern:**
 - Requires an organized structure with order among various functional units.
 - Eg: Within the Indian village, there exists an order and pattern among various functional constituents or units. The economic, political, religious, and other subsystems coexist and interact, forming a structured social organization.
- **Functional Unity:**
 - The unity between constituents is established through functional relationships.
 - Eg: The unity within the Indian village is established through functional relationships between its constituents. Economic activities, religious practices, and social interactions contribute to the overall stability and functioning of the village as a social system.
- **Maintenance:**
 - Achieved through socialization and social control, vital for the system's longevity.
 - Eg: The Indian village's endurance as a social system hinges on maintenance, which combines socialization, ensuring the transmission of cultural norms to younger generations and social control. The latter, involving the enforcement of rules, is vital for maintaining order and preventing disruptions that could jeopardize the continuity of the social system.

How can we say Indian Village as a Social System?

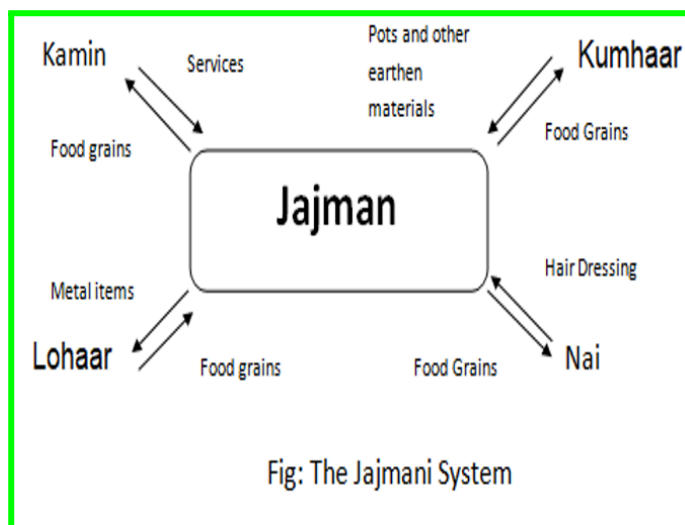
Now, if we look at the Indian village, we find all the important features of the social system in it.

- There is **constant interaction between the individuals** and there is no anonymity because of the small population and high density of population.

1. Caste and Jajmani System:

- **Plurality of actors:** Different castes (Brahmins, artisans, service castes) form multiple actors in constant interaction.
- **Order and pattern:** Caste hierarchy gives a fixed order, while Jajmani defines who provides what service.
- **Functional unity:** Interdependence in Jajmani (e.g., barber cuts hair, farmer gives grain) keeps the village running like a body with organs.
- This shows that caste-Jajmani is not isolated, it is a **subsystem ensuring economic and ritual order**.





2. Panchayati Raj System:

- **Aims and objectives:** Ensures local governance, justice, and development. Avoids aimlessness by setting common goals.
- **Order and pattern:** Democratic rules, elections, and dispute resolution bring stability in social and political life.
- **Maintenance:** Social control is exercised by panchayats, reducing conflict and enforcing norms.
- Therefore, Panchayat works as the **political subsystem** of the village, aligning with Parsons' idea of maintaining order.

3. Joint Family System:

- **Plurality of actors:** Many generations live together, interacting daily as actors in a shared household.
- **Functional unity:** Family members divide roles—elders guide, adults earn, children learn. Unity arises from shared labor and values.
- **Maintenance:** Socialization of children, discipline of members, and transmission of culture ensure continuity.
- The joint family is the **socialization and control subsystem**, ensuring value transmission.

Summary:

- Caste-Jajmani = **Economic-ritual order**
- Panchayati Raj = **Political order and control**
- Joint Family = **Socialization and cultural maintenance**
- Together, they fulfill all **five features of Parsons' social system**: plurality, aims, order, functional unity, and maintenance.
- Therefore, the Indian village is a **cohesive social system**, and within the larger Indian society, it acts as a **subsystem**.

In summary, the Indian village, with its constant interaction, deep-rooted social structures like the caste system and Jajmani norms, and the role of Panchayati Raj and joint family systems in socialization and control, exhibits all the crucial features of a social system. Therefore, it can be confidently affirmed that the Indian village serves as a cohesive and functioning social system within the broader societal framework.

TRADITIONAL CULTURE:

Definition

- **George Foster**, an American anthropologist, developed the concept of "**Traditional Culture**" from his fieldwork in **Mexico** (Latin America).
- He defined it as the **cultural practices and beliefs transmitted from one generation to the next**, creating continuity and stability in society.

Key Features

1. **Stability and Coherence**
 - Traditions are preserved carefully, often through **oral transmission** (songs, rhymes, rituals).
 - People follow the path of their **forefathers**, ensuring continuity.
2. **Identity and Continuity**
 - Provides a **sense of belonging and order** in society.
 - Festivals, fairs, and community gatherings reinforce cultural values.
3. **Adaptiveness and Change**
 - While traditions are stable, they may **adapt slowly** to the environment and new challenges.
 - However, change is often resisted if it threatens core cultural values.

How it Creates Barriers to Social Change

- Cultural patterns may **resist modernization** or new practices.
- Traditions can become **cultural barriers** that hinder reforms.
- Example:
 - **Gender roles** in rural Africa limit women's education and employment.
 - **Resistance to Western medicine** among indigenous groups due to faith in traditional healing.
 - **Resource use in tribal South America** (hunting, fishing traditions) conflicting with conservation laws.

Indian Examples of Traditional Culture as a Barrier

1. Caste System

- The caste system is one of the oldest cultural practices in India.
- It enforces **rigid social segregation** where interaction, marriage, and even residence are shaped by caste.
- Higher castes traditionally controlled resources and rituals, while lower castes were marginalized.
- This system **limits social mobility** and blocks reforms aimed at equality. For example, Dalits continue to face exclusion in village resources such as wells and temples.

2. Sanitation Practices

- A study by _____ found that Hindus were far less likely than Muslims to use toilets, even at the same income level.
- The traditional belief that **open defecation away from the home is "purer"** than keeping waste inside the house acts as a cultural barrier to modern sanitation.
- This leads to high levels of open defecation in India, contributing to child mortality and poor health outcomes, despite government investments in sanitation (e.g., Swachh Bharat Abhiyan).

3. Caste Segregation in Villages (Karnataka Case)

- Research by _____ shows that **intra-village segregation in Karnataka is greater than black-white segregation in the American South**.
- Ethnographic research (e.g., _____) documents how residential space in rural India mirrors **caste hierarchy**.
- **Village example: Amminabhavi** (near Dharwad, Karnataka) is a classic case:
 - Dalits (formerly "untouchables," labelled Harijans in early studies)** are pushed to the **periphery** of the village.
 - Dominant landholding castes** occupy the **center of the village**.
 - Other worker castes such as **Talwars, Shepherds, and Washermen** are also relegated to the margins.
 - The **village headman** and his kin control the **best land parcels**, often living in a large "manor house."
- Ambedkar famously called Indian villages a **"sink of localism and a den of narrow-mindedness,"** pointing to such entrenched practices.

4. Child Marriage

- Rooted in cultural values of **family honor and purity**, girls are often married off at a young age.
- This traditional practice **restricts education and economic opportunities** for women.
- It also increases risks of **early pregnancies, poor health, and domestic violence**.
- Despite legal prohibition, it persists in many rural areas because it is deeply tied to traditional notions of social order.

5. Female Infanticide

- Traditional preference for **male children** has led to practices such as female infanticide and later, sex-selective abortions.
- This reflects cultural beliefs that sons ensure lineage, provide economic support, and perform last rites, while daughters are seen as a financial burden (due to dowry).
- The result is a **distorted sex ratio**, which itself becomes a barrier to gender equality and social reform.

Criticism:

- Too **simplistic**: assumes cultures are static.
- Overlooks that traditions are **dynamic, evolving, and negotiable**.
- Sometimes used to justify **cultural purity** and **exclude minorities**.

In conclusion, Foster's concept of **Traditional Culture** highlights the dual role of traditions in society. On one hand, they preserve identity, continuity, and stability, while on the other, they can act as barriers to social change, as seen in practices like **caste segregation** or **sanitation beliefs**. For meaningful development, it is essential that reforms engage with cultural values rather than work against them. In this sense, culture can be seen as both a **shield** that protects communities and a **wall** that obstructs progressive change unless addressed with sensitivity.



PYQs:

- Discuss the characteristics of the caste system in India. (20M/ 2020)
- Discuss the theories on the origin of the caste system and its criticism in India. Differentiate between caste, class, and race. (15M/2024)
- What are the different types of caste mobility in India? Highlight the various factors responsible for it. (20M/2025)
- Concept of dominant caste. (10M/ 2020)
- Do you think caste persists in contemporary India? Critically discuss. (15 M/ 2014)
- The Jajmani system and the contemporary market economy. (10M/ 2019)
- Tribe-Caste continuum. (10 M/ 2014)
- Write about the role of colonial administration in the development of anthropology in India. (15M/2019)
- Discuss the basic tenets of Jainism and its impact on Indian society. (15M/2023)
- Discuss the impact of Islam on Indian society. (20M/2020)
- Explain the impact of Buddhism and Jainism on Indian society. (20M/2018)
- Explain the impact of the concept of nature-man-spirit complex on the sustainable use of natural resources with suitable examples. (20 M/ 2021)
- Describe the concept of 'Sacred Complex' with an ethnographic example. (15 M/ 2014)
- Critically examine the contributions of Makhan Jha and B. N. Saraswati to the study of sacred complexes in India. (20 M/ 2018)
- Linguistic minorities in India. (10 M/2020)
- Discuss the constitutional safeguards for religious minorities in India. (15 M/2021)
- What are the social and political problems of religious minorities in India? (20 M/2020)
- Westernisation and Modernisation. (10M/2022)
- Concept of Sanskritization. (10M/2020)
- Impact of Panchayati Raj institutions in rural areas. (10M/2018)
- Describe the media as an instrument for social change. (15M/2017)
- Characteristics and communication between Little and Great Traditions. (10M/2025)
- Great tradition and little tradition. (10 M/2014)
- Village as a little republic. (10M/2023)
- Describe the different settlement patterns in rural India. (20 M/2020)
- Discuss the impact of globalization on Indian villages. (15 M/2020)
- Identify the theoretical concepts that have emerged out of village studies in India. (20M/2019)
- Agrarian social structure. (10 M/2018)
- Explain Indian village as a social system with an example. (20M/2016)



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